THE JAPANESE WAY

Timeless Principles for Global Leaders

NAJUNA SAVIOUR

First Edition, 2026

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The personal recollection at the opening is attributed to Duku Micheal as shared with the author. Institutional and historical examples are discussed with source notes. No endorsement by any organisation mentioned in this book is implied.

Dedication

To Duku Micheal,
who shared with me the story that lit the spark—
a quiet classroom in Japan that taught leadership without a word.

This book is because you told it.
May your journey inspire many more.

Acknowledgments

This book is the result of many minds, voices, and unseen hands.

To Duku Micheal, thank you for planting the seed.

To my mentors, family, and friends—your belief carried this vision.

To the youth of Uganda and the leaders of Africa rising—this is your time.

And to the people whose work in Japan and across Africa gives us something useful to study, question and adapt.

Special thanks to every reader who chooses character over comfort. You are the reason this book exists.

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A Note to the Reader

This book begins with a recollection shared by Duku Micheal. I did not witness the classroom episode, and the lecturer's words are presented as remembered speech, not as a verified transcript. One experience cannot describe every school or every person in Japan.

The book brings personal reflection into conversation with documented examples and practical exercises. Institutional sources tell us how organisations describe their principles and programmes; they are not, by themselves, proof that every stated ambition has been achieved.

Scenarios introduced with "imagine," "consider" or "suppose" are teaching illustrations. Their purpose is to help readers test a principle in their own work. They are not reported interviews or accounts of identified organisations.

The Japanese Way is an invitation to learn across cultures with judgment. Its central concern is what discipline, responsibility, respect for time and continuous improvement can mean in the lives of students, professionals, entrepreneurs and leaders.

Introduction

A Path That Transcends Borders

I did not visit Japan to write this book.

But Japan visited me—through a story.

Duku Micheal described arriving late for a lecture and discovering that the class had been waiting for him. That recollection, told more fully in Chapter 1, became the starting point for this book.

What stayed with me was the relationship between one person and everybody else in the room. A late arrival can seem private when we measure it only by the minutes on our own watch. In that classroom, the consequences had become visible. Other people had prepared themselves. A lecturer had work to do. A shared undertaking depended, in part, on someone who had not yet arrived.

I have returned to that story because it asks a question that extends well beyond punctuality. What do other people have to carry when I do not carry my part?

The answer may be a few minutes of waiting. It may be a colleague redoing unfinished work, a customer returning to an office for the third time, or a family living with uncertainty because a promise has become unreliable. Leadership begins to take a different shape when we recognise these connections. Our habits enter other people's lives.

There are limits to what one story can establish. It cannot describe every Japanese classroom, demonstrate a universal teaching practice, or tell us whether waiting would be appropriate in another situation. A child may be late because of something beyond their control. A student may need support that others cannot see. I am interested in the responsibility the episode awakened in Duku, not in prescribing collective waiting as a classroom rule.

His account opened a door. Research, reflection and practical judgment must take us through it.

Learning without putting a nation on a pedestal

The title of this book names a starting point for inquiry. It does not suggest that Japan has one personality or possesses an exclusive claim to discipline, integrity or care. Japanese organisations vary. Their published ideals can be contradicted by their conduct. A method that succeeds in one setting may disappoint elsewhere, including within Japan itself.

Admiration becomes more useful when it can survive an uncomfortable fact. A company can develop an influential approach to quality while also experiencing failures of oversight. A school system can cultivate cooperation while placing burdens on teachers. A dependable service can still need to change. We learn more by examining these tensions than by collecting only stories that confirm a flattering picture.

Nor should a book about leadership explain national prosperity entirely through personal character. Roads, electricity, education, public investment, political choices, international relationships and historical circumstances shape what people can achieve. A disciplined trader cannot personally repair an unreliable national power supply. An honest teacher cannot create a missing education budget by arriving earlier.

Yet institutions are also made of decisions. Someone decides whether a maintenance request is recorded. Someone decides whether a complaint deserves an answer. Someone decides whether an inconvenient result is reported accurately. The presence of structural constraints does not erase these choices, just as the existence of individual choices does not erase structural constraints.

This book works at their meeting point: the place where personal conduct becomes an organisational practice, and where organisational practice either supports or undermines public trust.

Written from Africa for a wider conversation

I write from Uganda, with a particular concern for the people building businesses, schools and institutions across Africa. I also write for readers elsewhere who recognise the same difficulties in their own surroundings. A promise can fail in Kampala or London. A thoughtful teacher can make a difference in Accra or Osaka. No passport exempts a leader from the need to learn.

Africa is not one working environment. Countries, communities and institutions differ in resources, histories, languages and expectations. Even two organisations on the same street can operate according to very different standards. Whenever this book proposes an application, the reader should ask what would have to change for it to work in their particular setting.

Cross-cultural learning begins with respect in both directions. We do not need to discard local knowledge to recognise the value of a practice developed elsewhere. A community's experience of cooperation, a craftsperson's practical skill, or an entrepreneur's understanding of customers may be precisely what makes an imported idea useful. Adaptation is intellectual work. It requires people who know the place well enough to recognise both its possibilities and its constraints.

How the argument develops

The first four chapters examine the personal and organisational foundations of dependable work. Discipline concerns the way we make and sustain commitments. Responsibility concerns our response to outcomes, especially uncomfortable ones. Punctuality asks us to treat time as something shared. Kaizen introduces improvement as a process of observation, testing and learning.

The next three chapters follow these principles into education, enterprise and innovation. They ask what a school teaches through its everyday arrangements, what a business owes the people who make its success possible, and what happens after an invention leaves the demonstration room and enters ordinary life.

The final chapters address adaptation and leadership across generations. A good practice has to survive a change of staff, a difficult month and the departure of its founder. Otherwise, what looks like an institution may depend entirely on one person's effort.

Each chapter includes an opportunity to act. These exercises are invitations to test a principle, not a promise that thirty days will transform a personality or repair a national system. Choose an action small enough to carry out and important enough to matter. Observe its effects. Ask the people affected what changed for them.

The question that began in a classroom will remain with us: what becomes possible when we take seriously the effect of our presence, our work and our decisions on other people?

It is for those who are tired of loud leadership with little substance. It is for those who want to build not just fast—but with honor.

Let us walk this way together.

This is The Japanese Way.

Part I

The Values That Built a Nation

Chapter 1

Discipline — The Foundation of Leadership

> *"Success is nothing more than a few simple disciplines, practiced every day."*
>
> — Jim Rohn

There are lessons that enter our lives through books, classrooms and formal training. Others arrive through a conversation. For me, one such conversation came through my friend Duku Micheal and the experiences he carried home from Japan. One of them was remarkably simple. He arrived late for a lecture. He expected, perhaps, what many of us would expect: the class would already be underway, and he would quietly find a seat.

Instead, he entered a room where everyone was seated. Silently. The lecture had not begun. In the words Duku recalled to me:

> *"Now that the missing student has arrived, we can begin."*

There was no shouting. Duku remembered the lesson, rather than a shouted reprimand. No long speech about discipline. Yet a lesson had already been taught.

Duku understood that his time did not belong only to him. His decision affected the lecturer. It affected his classmates. His presence mattered because he belonged to something larger than himself. He told me he did not arrive late again. That story became one of the doors through which I began looking more carefully at Japan. But as this book developed, I realized something important: the lesson was larger than punctuality. It was about discipline.

And discipline may be one of the least glamorous but most powerful forces behind dependable leadership.

Discipline Is Not Punishment

Many people encounter the word discipline first as children. You make a mistake. You are disciplined. You break a rule. There are consequences. It is therefore easy to grow into adulthood thinking that discipline is something someone else imposes upon us. But mature discipline is almost the opposite. It is what we impose upon ourselves when nobody is forcing us.

It is the ability to decide that something matters - and then behave as though it matters repeatedly. A disciplined person does not simply know what should be done. A disciplined person develops the habit of doing it. A disciplined organization goes one step further: it designs systems so that good performance does not depend entirely upon somebody remembering to behave exceptionally that day. This distinction is essential. Great institutions cannot survive permanently on motivation.

People become tired. Leaders change. Excitement disappears. Economic conditions change. Employees leave. Technology changes. The organization that survives is often the organization that turns its values into processes. Japan offers several useful examples of what happens when precision moves beyond individual intention and becomes institutional practice.

When a Train Timetable Becomes a Leadership Lesson

Consider the Tokaido Shinkansen. Running between Tokyo and Osaka, the route carries enormous numbers of passengers through one of the world's busiest transportation corridors.

JR Central reports that in fiscal 2024 it operated an average of 383 Shinkansen services per day, with capacity for as many as 18 trains per hour during peak operation. Yet the average delay per train in 2024 was only 1.4 minutes - and that figure included disruptions caused by natural disasters and other uncontrollable events. [12]

Those numbers deserve to be considered carefully. It would be easy to look at them and simply say: Japanese people are punctual. But that

explanation is too shallow. A railway does not achieve that reliability merely because passengers value time. Thousands of decisions must work together. Scheduling. Train maintenance. Driver preparation. Station operations. Safety procedures. Infrastructure. Communication. Contingency planning. Staff training. One weak point can affect the entire system.

JR Central itself emphasizes rigorous training as part of maintaining safe and prompt operation. That changes the lesson. The deeper lesson is not merely: Be on time. It is: Build a system capable of keeping its promises. That is discipline at institutional scale. Imagine applying that principle beyond railways. What if a hospital treated the patient's appointment as a promise? What if a business treated the delivery date as a promise?

What if a university treated the semester timetable as a promise? What if a government office treated the date written on an application form as a promise? What if I treated the deadline I gave my client as a promise? Suddenly punctuality becomes something larger than watching a clock. It becomes trust.

Your Reputation Is What Happens Repeatedly

One excellent performance can impress someone. Repeated performance builds reputation. This matters especially to entrepreneurs. A young entrepreneur may have a brilliant logo, beautiful website, impressive presentation and ambitious vision. But eventually the customer asks very ordinary questions. Did you deliver? Was the product good? Did it work? Did you answer when something went wrong? Can I trust you again? Businesses are rarely destroyed because their founders lacked dreams.

They are often damaged because execution became unpredictable. The same principle applies to careers. Talent may get someone's attention. Consistency often determines whether you are trusted with greater responsibility. The person who repeatedly arrives prepared becomes known for preparation. The developer who repeatedly

delivers reliable systems becomes known for reliability. The student who repeatedly does serious work develops intellectual discipline.

The public servant who repeatedly follows through becomes different from the stereotype people may have expected. The leader who repeatedly keeps commitments gradually changes organizational culture. Discipline compounds. So does indiscipline.

Toyota: Improvement as a Daily Practice

One of the most influential Japanese examples of disciplined organizational thinking comes from Toyota. The Toyota Production System is commonly discussed through concepts such as Just-in-Time, jidoka, waste reduction and continuous improvement. But one particularly important principle is easy to overlook: Toyota describes its system as one in which employees implement daily incremental kaizen - continuous improvement - throughout the organization. The word kaizen is now used around the world.

Yet its power can be lost when we reduce it to an inspirational slogan. Continuous improvement sounds attractive. Continuous improvement is difficult. It requires people to notice small problems before they become disasters. It requires the humility to admit: This process can be better. Toyota's published philosophy speaks repeatedly about quality, improvement and the belief that there is always a better way. Notice the difference between this and waiting for crisis.

Many organizations improve only when something has gone seriously wrong. A major customer complains. Money disappears. The system crashes. Employees resign. Sales collapse. Then suddenly everyone becomes interested in improvement. Kaizen asks a different question: Why should improvement wait for disaster? That question applies equally to an individual life. You do not have to wait until your finances collapse before creating financial discipline. You do not have to fail university before changing your study habits.

You do not have to lose clients before improving communication. You do not have to damage a relationship before learning

responsibility. You do not have to become a national crisis before reforming an institution. Small corrections made early are often cheaper than dramatic corrections made late.

Discipline Before Motivation

Motivation has value. But motivation is unreliable. There will be mornings when you feel inspired. There will also be mornings when you do not. There will be days when entrepreneurship feels exciting. There will be months when it feels exhausting. There will be semesters when a student is enthusiastic. There will be weeks when studying feels impossible. If success depends entirely upon emotional readiness, progress will always be unstable. Discipline answers:

I may not feel the same every day, but the standard remains. This does not mean becoming mechanical. It means developing structures that protect what matters. The writer has a writing schedule. The company has a process for following up customers. The student has study hours. The software team tests before deployment. The hospital has safety procedures. The musician rehearses. The accountant reconciles records. The institution documents decisions. The leader arrives prepared.

Ordinary practices create extraordinary reliability when they are repeated long enough.

A Message to the Student

There is a temptation for students to believe that professional discipline begins after graduation. It does not. University is not merely preparation through information. It is preparation through habit. How you treat today's assignment may eventually resemble how you treat tomorrow's client. How you manage today's lecture may resemble how you manage tomorrow's meeting. How you handle today's group project may reveal how you will someday handle colleagues. Qualifications matter. Character travels with the qualification.

This is why Duku's classroom experience is so important. The lesson was not: Fear the lecturer. The deeper lesson was: Understand that other people are affected by how you carry yourself. That is leadership training even before somebody receives a leadership title.

A Message to the Entrepreneur

African entrepreneurship is full of creativity. You can see it in technology, transportation, retail, agriculture, financial services, media, fashion, entertainment and countless informal businesses. But creativity alone is not enough to build an institution. The entrepreneur eventually has to move from: "I can do this." to: "We can reliably do this every time." That transition is difficult. It requires documented systems. Accounting. Customer support. Quality control. Human-resource procedures. Deadlines. Maintenance. Data. Training. Follow-up.

The founder cannot permanently be the only person who knows how everything works. At some point, discipline must move from the founder's head into the organization. That is the difference between hustle and institution building.

A Message to the Professional

Your workplace may not always reward discipline immediately. Sometimes the person who cuts corners seems to move faster. Sometimes the person who speaks loudly receives more attention than the person who quietly performs. Sometimes organizational culture itself may be frustrating. Yet there is still enormous value in becoming dependable. People eventually learn whom they can trust with difficult work. Your professional identity is being built long before somebody gives you a new title.

Every completed assignment is contributing to it. Every missed promise is also contributing to it. Leadership begins before promotion.

A Message to the Leader

For leaders, however, discipline carries another responsibility. You cannot demand standards you repeatedly violate. If meetings are supposed to begin at nine but senior leadership routinely arrives at ten, the written policy is not the real culture. The leader is teaching something more powerful than the policy: Standards are optional for important people. Soon everyone learns. Culture is not created only by what leadership says. Culture is created by what leadership repeatedly tolerates.

This is where the Japanese examples become useful - not because every Japanese institution is perfect, but because they invite us to ask whether our own systems reinforce the behaviour we claim to value.

The Danger of Taking Discipline Too Far

There is another side to this conversation, and we should not hide it. Admiring Japan should not require romanticising everything about Japanese working culture. Japan has also confronted the consequences of excessive work. Japan's Ministry of Health, Labour and Welfare publishes an annual White Paper on Measures to Prevent Karoshi, addressing overwork-related death and serious illness and the measures intended to prevent them. [13] This matters enormously to the argument of this book.

Discipline is valuable. Destruction is not discipline. Commitment is valuable. Exhaustion should not become a badge of honour. Responsibility toward an institution should not require abandoning responsibility toward one's health, family or humanity. Every cultural strength can become dangerous when separated from wisdom. So when I speak of learning from Japan, I do not mean: Work until you collapse. I mean:

Learn the systems that produce reliability, quality and responsibility - and also learn from the areas where those systems have had to confront their own limits. That makes cultural learning mature. We do not copy blindly. We observe. We question. We understand. We adapt.

Africa Does Not Need to Become Japan

This book is not an argument for cultural replacement. Africa has strengths Japan does not possess in the same form. There are traditions of extended family, spontaneous community support, social warmth, adaptability and entrepreneurial improvisation that deserve protection and development. The objective should not be to exchange one identity for another. It should be to ask: What makes us stronger? If punctuality increases trust, learn from it. If continuous improvement raises quality, learn from it.

If responsibility strengthens institutions, learn from it. If Japanese experience also demonstrates the dangers of excessive work, learn from that too. Then combine what is useful with what is already valuable within our own societies. This is what meaningful cultural exchange should accomplish.

When Discipline Becomes Development

Development is often discussed through large things. Highways. Airports. Technology parks. Factories. Universities. Investment. These are important. But every major system eventually depends upon ordinary human behaviour. A new hospital can be built. Will equipment be maintained? A new road can be constructed. Will maintenance continue after the opening ceremony? A digital government system can be launched. Will officials actually use it correctly? A university can build magnificent lecture halls. Will lectures begin?

An entrepreneur can raise capital. Will financial records be kept? A nation can produce strategic plans. Will anyone follow through? Infrastructure matters. Institutions matter. But discipline is what allows institutions to function after the excitement of launching them has passed. That may be one of the quietest lessons behind Japan's achievement. Not that Japanese people possess some mysterious quality unavailable to others. But that repeated standards, embedded into institutions, can produce extraordinary cumulative results.

And anything that can be learned can also be adapted.

The Beginning Is Smaller Than You Think

Perhaps you are reading this expecting some dramatic leadership transformation. Begin smaller. Look at one promise you repeatedly make. Maybe it is arriving somewhere at a particular time. Maybe it is responding to clients. Maybe it is studying. Maybe it is saving money. Maybe it is completing projects you start. Maybe it is maintaining records. Maybe it is preparing before meetings. Do not begin by announcing that everything will change. Change one repeatable behaviour.

Then protect it. Improve it. Measure it. Repeat it. That is where Kaizen and discipline meet. Leadership does not begin when the world notices you. Leadership begins when you become trustworthy in the things the world may never see. Duku walked into a classroom expecting a lecture. Before the lecturer had taught the first academic lesson of the day, another lesson had already been delivered. His presence mattered. His time mattered. His decision affected others.

And once he understood that, his behaviour changed. Perhaps that is where leadership begins for all of us. Not with authority. Not with applause. Not with position. But with the realization: What I do affects more than me. That realization produces responsibility. Responsibility repeated becomes discipline. And discipline, over time, becomes character.

Reflections for the Reader

When was the last time I kept a difficult promise?

Do I treat my time—and others' time—with honor?

Where have I compromised consistency for comfort?

Action Steps

Personal Practice: Identify one commitment in your life that has become unreliable. For the next thirty days, create a simple system that makes keeping that commitment easier.

Leadership Practice: Ask whether the standards you expect from other people are visible in your own behaviour.

Institutional Practice: Select one recurring problem in your organization. Instead of solving the symptom again, document the process that creates it and make one measurable improvement.

Final Reflection

Discipline is not a rule—it is a rhythm. It is the steady beat that great leaders march to while the world rushes ahead without direction.

If you want to lead others, start by leading your time, your actions, and your commitments.

This is The Japanese Way.

Chapter 2

Responsibility — Owning the Outcome

"The price of greatness is responsibility."

— Winston Churchill

Some lessons become stronger when the facts challenge the story. When Duku Micheal first shared his experiences and impressions of Japan with me, one of the stories that stayed with me concerned a Japanese minister who, as he remembered it, had resigned after arriving significantly late. It was a powerful story.

It seemed to communicate an extraordinary standard of public responsibility: that leadership was not merely a privilege but an obligation, and that even something as apparently ordinary as lateness could be treated seriously. It helped inspire my thinking. But inspiration is not the same thing as evidence. As this book moved from an idea toward publication, that story needed to be checked. And what we found was more complicated.

When Research Corrects the Story

In February 2019, Japan's Olympic Minister Yoshitaka Sakurada arrived approximately three minutes late to a parliamentary committee meeting. He apologized publicly. Opposition lawmakers criticized the lateness as disrespectful and demanded his resignation. But he did not resign because he was late. Two months later, in April 2019, Sakurada did resign - but for a different reason. He had made remarks that were regarded as hurtful to communities affected by the 2011 earthquake and tsunami.

The official Japanese Prime Minister's Office records Prime Minister Shinzo Abe saying that Sakurada had offered his resignation because

of those remarks. Abe accepted it and also publicly stated that responsibility for appointing the minister lay with him as Prime Minister. That distinction matters. A weaker book could simply repeat the more dramatic version. A stronger book must say: The story that inspired us was not entirely accurate.

And perhaps this correction itself belongs in a chapter about responsibility. Because responsibility begins with the willingness to accept reality even when reality interferes with the story we would prefer to tell. If evidence corrects us, we correct ourselves. If a mistake belongs to us, we own it. If something has gone wrong under our leadership, we do not begin by asking: Who can I blame? We begin with: What is my responsibility here?

Responsibility Is Larger Than Blame

Responsibility and blame are not the same thing. Blame looks backward and asks: Who caused this? Responsibility asks another question: What must happen now? Sometimes the same person answers both questions. Sometimes not. A leader may inherit a problem he did not create. A business owner may have an employee make a mistake without his knowledge. A government minister may oversee thousands of people and never personally touch the process that failed.

A parent may face circumstances outside their control. A project manager may inherit badly written software. A university leader may take over an institution already carrying deep problems. Responsibility does not necessarily mean saying: Everything was my fault. It means saying: I will not pretend that this has nothing to do with me merely because I can identify someone beneath me who made the immediate mistake. That is a very different form of leadership.

The Difference Between Position and Responsibility

Many people want authority. Responsibility is what authority costs. The higher a person rises within an organization, the greater the temptation can become to enjoy the privileges of leadership while

transferring every failure downward. When results are good: I led this team. When results are bad: My people failed me. That is not leadership. If we accept credit when the institution succeeds, we must be prepared to examine our role when it fails.

The Japanese political examples above do not prove that every Japanese politician accepts responsibility or that Japanese public life is free from scandal. It clearly is not. But they do give us an interesting language of accountability. When Minister Sakurada resigned in 2019, Prime Minister Abe did not merely announce that the minister was gone. He publicly stated that the responsibility for appointing him lay with the Prime Minister himself.

That sentence is worth examining beyond politics. Imagine hearing it inside a business. I hired this person. I therefore have to examine the recruitment process. Or inside a project: I approved this plan. I therefore have to examine the assumptions behind it. Or inside a family: I made this commitment. I therefore need to confront why I did not keep it. Responsibility does not diminish authority. Properly exercised, it makes authority believable.

Toyota and the Cost of a Quality Crisis

Responsibility becomes even clearer when an organization faces a serious failure. In 2009 and 2010, Toyota faced a major global quality crisis involving recalls affecting millions of vehicles, including concerns about accelerator pedals and braking systems. Toyota could not solve such a crisis through advertising. Its reputation had been built partly around reliability and quality. When the quality itself was being questioned, the issue struck directly at the company's identity.

Toyota's own corporate history records that President Akio Toyoda publicly addressed the crisis, established a Special Committee for Global Quality under his own chairmanship, and personally announced further recall measures. He subsequently appeared before the United States Congress in February 2010. The company's account describes a response that involved leadership, dealers, suppliers and employees. A quality failure had to be addressed through the

organisation that produced and supported the vehicles. [14] That is important.

Responsibility was not simply: We apologize. It had to become: What must change? Committees. Quality review. Engineering investigation. Recall procedures. Communication. Organizational learning. This distinction matters because apologies can become another form of performance. A leader can stand before cameras, apologize beautifully, and return the next day to exactly the system that produced the failure. That is not responsibility. That is ceremony.

Learning from failure in Japan too

A book inspired by Japan must examine failures within Japanese organisations. Otherwise it asks readers to learn from a carefully edited image.

On 20 December 2023, Toyota published a statement about additional certification irregularities at Daihatsu. It reported findings from an independent third-party committee, shipment suspensions and the need for changes extending beyond the certification process to management, organisation and staff development. Toyota also acknowledged that it had not understood the situation in Daihatsu's certification operations. These were serious failures within a group associated with manufacturing quality. [2]

This account provides a more demanding lesson than a story in which a leader immediately does everything right. A respected name does not remove the need for oversight. Published principles do not guarantee that people can follow them under actual operating pressures.

My interpretation is that responsibility has to reach the conditions under which work is performed. If an investigation ends with one employee receiving a warning while unrealistic demands remain untouched, it may leave the next employee facing the same choices. The response should examine how decisions were approved, how concerns travelled, and what information leaders failed to seek.

The company statement establishes what the companies disclosed at that time. It does not, by itself, prove that all corrective measures later succeeded. That distinction matters whenever leaders announce reform. An announcement is a commitment to be checked.

An Apology Without Correction Is Incomplete

There is a leadership principle we should carry throughout this book: Responsibility becomes credible when acknowledgement produces correction. Suppose I tell a client: "I'm sorry the project is late." The apology may be sincere. But if my next three projects are also late for the same reason, eventually the words lose their meaning. Suppose a company apologizes every month because its service keeps failing. At some point the customer does not want another apology.

The customer wants a working system. Suppose leaders repeatedly say: "We take full responsibility." Yet nobody changes the process, the oversight, the staffing, the incentives or the culture that created the problem. Those words become empty. Responsibility asks us to move through several stages: Recognize it. Own it. Understand it. Correct it. Learn from it. Prevent its repetition. That is a far more demanding standard than simply saying sorry.

When Responsibility Becomes Institutional Memory

One of the most difficult Japanese examples in this book comes from railway history. On 25 April 2005, a JR West train derailed on the Fukuchiyama Line near Amagasaki. The train entered a curve at approximately 116 kilometres per hour where the speed limit was 70 kilometres per hour. The driver and 106 passengers were killed, and hundreds of passengers were injured. This is not a story to romanticize. People lost their lives.

Families were permanently changed. The appropriate lesson cannot be reduced to a motivational slogan. What is noteworthy for our discussion of responsibility is what happened to the event inside the institution's memory. JR West preserves a public account of the

accident and its consequences. The event remains part of the organisation's documented history. [15]

Preserving such an account gives later generations of staff a place to begin learning about what happened. A published commitment must, of course, be judged alongside actual practice. The leadership question is whether that memory continues to change decisions about equipment, procedures, communication and the treatment of safety concerns. There is an important leadership principle here: Some failures should never disappear from institutional memory.

An organization that forgets how people were hurt may eventually recreate the conditions that hurt them.

Organizations Need Memory

This is something institutions everywhere should consider. When leadership changes, how much organizational knowledge disappears? A new manager enters. Old files vanish. Nobody remembers why a particular policy was created. Nobody documents what failed. People who lived through the original problem eventually leave. Five years later, another generation repeats it. This is one reason documentation matters. Incident reports matter. Post-project reviews matter. Financial audits matter. Safety investigations matter. Meeting minutes matter. Version histories matter.

Policies matter. Not because paperwork is inherently valuable. But because organizations need memory. If an organization cannot remember its failures, it cannot reliably learn from them. This principle is particularly important for young institutions. A startup may initially have five people. Everyone remembers everything. Then it becomes twenty. Then fifty. Then the founding staff leave. Unless experience has been transformed into systems, the organization repeatedly starts from zero. Responsibility therefore includes something surprising: preserving lessons.

The African Question

Across Africa, we often discuss accountability primarily in relation to government. That conversation is necessary. But responsibility must be broader than politics. It belongs in businesses. Churches. Schools. Families. NGOs. Technology companies. Universities. Hospitals. Media organizations. Professional associations. Startups. Community organizations. The easiest form of accountability is demanding it from somebody powerful and distant. The harder form begins much closer. What happens when my customer is disappointed? What happens when my organization mishandles money?

What happens when my project misses the deadline? What happens when my employee fails because I never trained them properly? What happens when my software breaks? What happens when my institution makes a promise it cannot keep? National cultures are not created only inside presidential offices. They are created wherever human beings accept or avoid responsibility.

A Message to the Entrepreneur

Entrepreneurship provides endless opportunities to blame. The economy. The customer. Government. Employees. Suppliers. The bank. Investors. Competition. Electricity. Internet. Taxes. There may be truth in several of these complaints. External conditions can genuinely make business difficult. But entrepreneurship requires distinguishing between: what I cannot control and what I have failed to control. That distinction can change a company. Perhaps your customer did not understand the product. Did you explain it clearly?

Perhaps an employee performed badly. Was the employee properly trained? Perhaps cash disappeared. Were there financial controls? Perhaps the project became unprofitable. Was the scope documented? Perhaps a client kept changing requirements. Was there a change-control process? Perhaps customers stopped buying. Did you listen to them? Responsibility does not mean denying difficult circumstances. It means refusing to use circumstances as an excuse not to examine ourselves.

A Message to the Software Developer

Technology offers a particularly useful example. When software fails, the first temptation may be: The user did something wrong. Sometimes they did. But good engineering asks another question: Why was the system able to fail this way? Can validation prevent it? Can the interface make the correct action clearer? Can logging help us understand what happened? Can backups reduce the consequences? Can automated tests detect the problem before deployment? Can permissions prevent unauthorized actions?

Can monitoring warn us earlier? Responsibility transforms failure into engineering. Without responsibility, bugs become arguments. With responsibility, bugs become information.

A Message to the Professional

You will make mistakes. That is almost guaranteed. Professionalism is not the absence of mistakes. It is partly demonstrated by what happens after them. A weak response sounds like: "I wasn't told." "That wasn't my department." "They sent it late." "I thought somebody else was doing it." A stronger response might be: "I misunderstood what was required. Here is what I have done to correct it." Or:

"I depended on information that arrived late, but I should have communicated the risk earlier." Or: "This failure occurred within my area of responsibility. I am investigating why and will propose a correction." Notice what happens. You do not necessarily accept blame for things you did not cause. You accept responsibility for the part that belongs to you. That is maturity.

A Message to the Student

Students sometimes believe that excuses disappear after graduation. They do not. They simply become more expensive. At university, an excuse may cost marks. In employment, it may cost trust. In business, it may cost money. In medicine, engineering, transportation or public administration, failure to accept responsibility can affect lives.

University therefore offers a relatively safe place to develop an important habit: When you get something wrong, investigate yourself before defending yourself.

Not because you should live in shame. Because honest self-examination accelerates growth.

Responsibility Is Not Shame

This distinction is important. A culture of responsibility should not become a culture of humiliation. If every mistake produces public destruction, people learn to hide mistakes. That can make organizations more dangerous. Employees conceal problems. Managers manipulate reports. Teams fear bad news. Nobody wants to tell leadership that something has failed. By the time reality becomes impossible to hide, the damage is much larger. Responsible leadership creates enough psychological safety for people to say:

Something is wrong. I made an error. We need help. This process is failing. The objective is not to make people afraid of mistakes. The objective is to make people unwilling to conceal them. That difference is profound.

Truth Must Travel Upward

Many institutional failures are not caused because nobody knew there was a problem. Some happen because people lower in the organization knew - but the truth could not move upward. Maybe the boss did not like bad news. Maybe reporting failure damaged careers. Maybe employees believed speaking honestly would be interpreted as disloyalty. Maybe the organization rewarded appearances rather than reality. Eventually leadership operates inside an illusion. Everything looks fine until suddenly it isn't.

Responsible leaders therefore need people who can contradict them. They need data capable of embarrassing them. They need audits. They need feedback. They need customers who complain. They need employees who can say: This is not working. Truth is not an enemy of leadership. Truth is one of leadership's most important instruments.

Toyota's philosophy includes the principle of genchi genbutsu - going to the source to understand facts before making decisions. Its Toyota Way also emphasizes observing thoroughly, working with integrity and continual improvement. [19] That principle extends beyond manufacturing. When there is a problem: Go and understand it. Do not lead only from reports. Do not defend yourself before discovering what happened. Do not make the narrative more important than the facts.

Owning the Outcome Without Controlling Everything

There is another misunderstanding about responsibility. Responsible people sometimes begin believing they must control everything. They do not. A leader can delegate work without delegating accountability. A CEO cannot personally answer every customer call. A university vice-chancellor cannot personally teach every lecture. A minister cannot personally perform every government task. A founder cannot write every line of code indefinitely. Leadership eventually requires delegation. But delegation must include: Clear expectations. Competent people.

Authority appropriate to the responsibility. Monitoring. Feedback. Systems. Escalation. Accountability. Then when something goes wrong, the leader asks: Was the person capable? Were expectations clear? Did they have the resources? Was there supervision? Did our system detect the problem? What was their responsibility? What was mine? That is much more useful than simply finding somebody to sacrifice.

Africa's Institutions Will Be Built by People Who Stay With Problems

There is great excitement across the continent about innovation. We should celebrate it. But building nations requires something less glamorous as well: staying with problems long enough to solve them. Many people enjoy launching. Fewer enjoy maintaining. Opening ceremonies are exciting. Maintenance budgets are not. New software

is exciting. Updating it five years later is not. Launching a company is exciting. Reconciling its accounts every month is not. Building a hospital is visible.

Maintaining equipment is quieter. Announcing a national strategy creates headlines. Following implementation year after year does not. Responsibility begins after the excitement. That is where institutions are truly built.

Leadership Is Saying: It Stops With Me

There comes a stage in leadership where excuses become increasingly expensive. You may not have created every problem. But you have accepted a position from which you can influence what happens next. That is the burden and privilege of leadership. Sometimes responsibility means apologizing. Sometimes it means resigning. Sometimes it means staying and fixing the problem. Sometimes it means disciplining somebody. Sometimes it means changing yourself. Sometimes it means redesigning the system.

Sometimes it means admitting that you do not yet know what went wrong. The action will differ. The principle remains: Do not run away from the outcome simply because the outcome is uncomfortable.

The Story We Corrected

I return to the story Duku told me because I believe its correction teaches something valuable. He was not writing a research paper when he shared it with me. He was a friend telling me the experiences and stories about Japan that had impressed him. It opened my eyes. That was enough. But now I am writing a book. My responsibility has changed. The story that inspired me is allowed to open the door.

Evidence must determine what eventually passes through it. And so the story changed. A minister was indeed criticized and publicly apologized for arriving only a few minutes late. The same minister later resigned. But the resignation was over different remarks - not his lateness. We lose nothing by admitting that. We gain something much

more important: trust. The Japanese Way should never ask its readers to pursue integrity while being careless with its own evidence.

That would contradict the entire book.

Responsibility Begins Here

Perhaps the most useful question from this chapter is not: Who should take responsibility? Ask instead: What belongs to me? Not everything. But something. There is probably one unfinished commitment. One repeated excuse. One mistake that you have defended longer than necessary. One system you know needs correction. One conversation you have avoided. One customer who deserves an answer. One project whose problems you already understand. One habit you keep blaming on circumstances.

Responsibility starts there. Not with national transformation. Not with somebody else's failure. With what belongs to you. Own it. Understand it. Repair what can be repaired. Learn. Then build differently. That is how responsibility becomes character. And when enough people carry responsibility into their professions, businesses and institutions, character begins to become culture.

Reflections for the Reader

When something goes wrong, do I look outward or inward?

Which part of the outcome is mine to acknowledge and repair?

How can I delegate work while remaining accountable for my own decisions?

Action Steps

Personal Practice: Choose one situation in your life where your first instinct has been to explain why something was not your fault. Write down only the portion that genuinely belongs to you. Take one corrective action.

Leadership Practice: The next time something fails within a team you lead, do not begin by asking who is to blame. Ask first: What in our leadership, communication or system allowed this to happen?

Institutional Practice: Choose one recurring organizational failure. Document what happened, why it happened, what was changed, and how the lesson will be preserved for future staff.

A Principle to Carry Forward

Responsibility is not accepting blame for everything. It is refusing to abandon the part of the outcome that belongs to you.

Final Reflection

The best leaders do not shift blame—they shift the standard. They make others rise not through fear, but through example. They don't ask, "Whose fault is it?" They ask, "How do I make it right?"

Responsibility becomes a foundation for trust when we acknowledge what belongs to us and follow through on the repair.

This is The Japanese Way.

Chapter 3

Punctuality — The Respect Behind Time

"Punctuality is more than logistics. It is a leadership ethic."

— Najuna Saviour

Time is one of the few resources every human being receives in the same daily quantity. Twenty-four hours. The wealthy cannot purchase a twenty-fifth. The powerful cannot recover yesterday. The student, entrepreneur, government official, engineer, teacher and farmer all live within the same boundary. What differs is how we treat that boundary - and how we treat the time belonging to other people.

That is why punctuality is much more than arriving early enough to avoid embarrassment. At its deepest level, punctuality communicates something about respect. It says: I recognize that your time has value too. That lesson was hidden inside the classroom experience that first drew me toward this book. Duku Micheal arrived late. The class had not begun. Everyone was there. Everyone except him. When he entered, the lecturer announced:

"Now that the missing student has arrived, we can begin." Duku did not describe a punishment. He described realization. The class had been waiting. His lateness had ceased to be a private matter. That may be one of the most important things punctuality teaches us: Time is personal, but it is also social.

What Does It Mean to Be Late?

Suppose ten people agree to meet at 9:00 a.m. Nine arrive at nine. One arrives at 9:30. The late person may think: I lost thirty minutes. But that is mathematically incomplete. If nine people each spent thirty minutes waiting, the group may have lost much more than thirty

minutes of collective productive time. This is why lateness scales. An individual habit eventually becomes an organizational cost. A meeting begins late. The next appointment is delayed.

Someone misses transport. Another meeting is postponed. A customer waits. A decision moves to tomorrow. A project slips another day. One person's fifteen minutes can travel surprisingly far. The opposite is also true. When schedules are dependable, people can coordinate. And coordination is one of the foundations of complex societies.

The Shinkansen: Punctuality as a System

Japan's railway system is one of the most visible examples through which outsiders encounter Japanese attitudes toward time. The Tokaido Shinkansen connects Tokyo, Nagoya and Osaka through one of Japan's most important economic corridors. It does not achieve precision by asking drivers to "try to be punctual." Punctuality is engineered.

JR Central reports that the Tokaido Shinkansen operates as many as 18 trains per hour at peak periods. Its published figures for 2024 show an average delay of about 1.4 minutes per train, including delays caused by natural disasters and other disruptions. Think about what this requires.

A railway timetable is not only a document. It is the final expression of thousands of coordinated systems: maintenance, signalling, station management, cleaning, boarding, driver training, track inspection, communication, safety procedures, emergency planning, passenger information, and countless decisions made before most passengers even enter the station. This is why punctuality should not be reduced to personality. Reliable timekeeping is often infrastructure plus culture plus accountability.

The Most Interesting Train Was Twenty Seconds Early

There is an almost unbelievable railway story from Japan that is actually documented. In November 2017, a train on the Tsukuba

Express left MinamiNagareyama Station twenty seconds earlier than scheduled. It was supposed to depart at 9:44:40. It departed at 9:44:20. The railway company apologized.

No passenger complaint had triggered the apology. Reporting at the time said the crew had failed to properly check the departure time, and the company instructed staff to follow the timetable correctly. At first, this story sounds almost humorous. Twenty seconds? Some readers living in places where transport may arrive thirty minutes late could reasonably wonder whether this is excessive. But there is a deeper principle worth noticing.

The problem was not simply that the train moved at the wrong second. The problem was that the published schedule represented a promise. And interestingly, leaving early can violate a promise just as certainly as leaving late. Imagine arriving at the platform at exactly the advertised time and discovering that your train has already gone. Being early is not always punctual. Being predictable is punctual. That distinction matters enormously in leadership.

A Deadline Is Also a Promise

Many of us think of deadlines as suggestions until somebody begins chasing us. A client says Friday. We deliver Monday. A meeting says 10:00. We start at 10:45. An application says fourteen working days. The applicant returns after a month and nobody knows where it is. A contractor promises completion in June. August arrives. People gradually adapt. They begin adding hidden buffers. If someone says ten o'clock, perhaps they mean eleven.

If delivery is promised on Friday, expect next week. If a government office says seven days, prepare for thirty. When this becomes normal, an invisible cost enters society: people can no longer confidently plan around one another. That is a trust problem. The importance of punctuality therefore reaches far beyond etiquette. It influences economic coordination. If suppliers cannot predict when goods will arrive, businesses hold extra stock.

If customers cannot predict service time, they lose hours waiting. If professionals do not respect appointments, schedules collapse. If construction milestones mean little, other contractors cannot plan. If institutions cannot meet their own timelines, citizens begin navigating them through persistence, relationships or improvisation rather than predictable procedure. Time becomes expensive.

Japan Even Documents Delay

Another small detail tells us something about how seriously time coordination is treated. JR East operates an online delay certificate system. For covered conventional railway lines, when delays reach roughly five minutes or more, the company publishes certificates showing the degree of delay for different time periods. The system explicitly records delays in categories such as ten minutes, twenty minutes, thirty minutes and beyond. [16] Why does this matter?

Because a delay in one system can affect a person's responsibility within another. A worker may be late to work. A student may be late to class. An appointment may be missed. The railway's delay therefore becomes information that other institutions can recognize. Again, the deeper principle is coordination. A sophisticated society does not merely demand punctuality from individuals. It also acknowledges when systems themselves have failed to deliver on time.

There is responsibility on both sides.

Punctuality Is Not Perfection

We must be careful here. It would be easy to turn Japan into mythology. Japanese trains are not magically immune to delays. The existence of an official delay-certificate system is itself a reminder that disruption occurs even in a railway system known for reliability. Weather happens. Equipment fails. Accidents happen. Emergencies occur. Human beings make mistakes. So the lesson is not: Japan is always on time. The better lesson is:

Japan has built strong expectations, systems and corrective mechanisms around time reliability. That is much more useful because it can be learned. Perfection cannot. Standards can.

Respecting Time Does Not Mean Worshipping the Clock

There is another danger. A discussion of punctuality can become rigid. Human beings are not machines. A parent may experience an emergency. Traffic may stop unexpectedly. A colleague may become ill. Weather may make travel unsafe. A student may face circumstances no timetable anticipated. Wisdom requires context. The goal is not to create societies in which a person becomes worthless because they arrived three minutes late. The goal is to distinguish between: exception and habit.

An emergency explains lateness. A culture of casual lateness normalizes it. These are different. Compassion should respond to the first. Discipline should challenge the second.

"African Time"

Across parts of Africa, people sometimes jokingly speak of "African time." The phrase can refer to a relaxed approach to schedules, events beginning considerably later than advertised, or an assumption that stated time and actual time are different things. Humour can make difficult truths easier to discuss. But we should be careful not to convert poor habits into identity. Lateness is not African DNA. Punctuality is not Japanese DNA.

Both are behaviours reinforced by expectations, incentives and systems. That distinction matters enormously. If we say: This is just who we are, then improvement becomes cultural betrayal. But if we say: This is something we have normalized, then change becomes possible. Africa does not lose its warmth, community or spontaneity by respecting time. A Ugandan does not become Japanese by beginning a meeting when it was scheduled.

A Nigerian company does not lose its identity by delivering on the promised date. A Kenyan university does not become culturally

foreign by beginning lectures on time. Punctuality is not an ethnicity. It is a practice.

The Entrepreneur and the Cost of "Tomorrow"

Entrepreneurs sometimes underestimate how much credibility is contained in a date. A customer asks: "When will it be ready?" The entrepreneur says: "Tomorrow." Tomorrow arrives. Nothing. "Maybe tomorrow evening." Then Friday. Then Monday. Eventually the customer stops asking. Perhaps the technical work was excellent. Perhaps the entrepreneur is genuinely talented. But something has been damaged. Trust. Now imagine another business. It says: "Delivery will take seven days."

On day five, it realizes there will be a delay. It contacts the customer immediately: "We have encountered this problem. The revised delivery date is Wednesday. Here is what has been completed and what remains." The customer may not be happy. But uncertainty has been reduced. Professionalism does not mean that schedules never change. It means changes are managed responsibly. That is a critical distinction.

Time Management Is Really Commitment Management

People often say: I need to manage my time better. But time itself cannot be managed. The clock will continue. What we manage are: priorities, commitments, attention, energy, and expectations. If you say yes to ten things that require twenty hours and you only have eight, the problem is not the clock. The problem is commitment design. This is why punctuality is connected to integrity. Sometimes chronic lateness is actually chronic overpromising.

We want to please everybody. So we promise everything. Then reality arrives. A mature leader learns that saying: I cannot complete that by Friday may be more responsible than saying: Yes and failing silently.

A Message to the Student

Students often experience time as something imposed externally. A bell rings. A lecturer sets a deadline. An examination has a duration. But adult life gradually removes some of these external structures. Nobody may force you to prepare. Nobody may call to ensure you started. Nobody may stand behind you while you finish. This is why education should develop internal time discipline before external supervision disappears. If class begins at eight, try treating eight as eight.

If an assignment is due Friday, do not make Friday the day you begin understanding it. If a group is depending on your part, remember that your delay is no longer solely yours. The point is not merely academic success. You are rehearsing reliability.

A Message to the Professional

In professional life, punctuality communicates preparation. Arriving at a meeting at the exact start time while still searching for documents is technically arrival. It may not be readiness. Professional punctuality often means arriving with enough margin to: open the file, test the equipment, understand the agenda, settle mentally, and begin when promised. This applies online too. A virtual meeting scheduled at 2:00 does not become less real because nobody travelled to a physical room.

Time remains time.

A Message to the Entrepreneur

Entrepreneurs should measure time more seriously than almost anybody. Every repeated delay may indicate a process problem. Ask: Why are projects always late? Are estimates unrealistic? Are requirements unclear? Are customers changing scope? Are employees overloaded? Are approvals slow? Is procurement unpredictable? Are we saying yes to work we do not have capacity to deliver? A late project should not simply produce stress. It should produce information. That is where punctuality meets Kaizen.

A Message to the Leader

The leader sets the hidden clock of an organization. Suppose the official meeting time is 9:00. The director normally appears at 9:40. Eventually staff learn something: 9:00 does not mean 9:00. The actual start time becomes the director's arrival. Now imagine the director complains that employees are undisciplined. The organization will hear the words. But it will follow the example. A culture of punctuality cannot be delegated downward. Leadership must embody it.

The Public-Service Question

Time is especially important where citizens depend on institutions. A citizen taking a day away from work to visit a public office is spending something. Transport. Income. Energy. Childcare. Opportunity. Waiting is therefore not always free merely because no invoice is issued. The same applies in hospitals. A patient who waits six hours has paid in time. The same applies in courts. A case repeatedly postponed carries human cost. The same applies to licensing.

A business waiting months for approval may lose investment or revenue. This is why institutional punctuality is not merely efficiency. Sometimes it is dignity.

When Time Becomes Trust

Suppose two companies offer the same product. One is slightly cheaper but unpredictable. The other reliably delivers when promised. Which one will many customers eventually prefer? Reliability itself has economic value. The same is true for countries. Investors evaluate predictability. Citizens evaluate predictability. Tourists evaluate predictability. Students evaluate predictability. A society where processes happen approximately when promised creates confidence. And confidence reduces friction. People spend less energy chasing. Less energy guessing. Less energy calling repeatedly.

Less energy building backup plans around institutional uncertainty. That energy can go somewhere more productive.

But There Must Be Room for Humanity

There is a danger in all high-performance cultures. The standard can become more important than the person. We must resist that. Punctuality should serve human coordination. Human beings should not become servants of punctuality. A leader who humiliates someone facing a genuine emergency has misunderstood the principle. The purpose of time discipline is not fear. It is trust. The purpose of schedules is not control for its own sake. It is coordination.

And the purpose of reliability is ultimately to help people live and work together more effectively. This balance is important throughout The Japanese Way. We are searching for principles worth adapting. Not importing every cultural pressure that may accompany them.

The Train That Left Too Early

Let us return to that twenty-second story. A train left early. No passenger complaints were reported. Another train was due only a few minutes later. And yet the operator acknowledged the mistake. Why does the story travel so powerfully around the world? Perhaps because it exposes something many societies quietly desire: the experience of being able to believe a timetable. Not because twenty seconds should dominate our lives.

But because promises should mean something. When a timetable says 9:44:40, a passenger should be able to organize their actions around that information. When a business says Friday, the customer should be able to plan around Friday. When a leader says the meeting begins at ten, people should not have to decode what "ten" really means.

When an institution says seven working days, the citizen should not have to know somebody inside the office to discover what happens next. Punctuality is one form of truthfulness. It aligns what we say with what actually happens.

The Classroom Again

Duku's classroom story therefore means more to me now than when I first heard it. At first I heard: Japanese people take punctuality seriously. Now I hear something deeper. One student was missing. The class had a shared expectation. His absence affected the group. When he arrived, nobody needed a long lecture on discipline. The environment itself communicated the standard. That may be the real ambition for our institutions. Not to spend every day shouting:

"Be punctual." "Be responsible." "Do quality work." But to build environments where the systems themselves quietly teach: This is how we do things here. That is when values become culture.

Punctuality Is Respect Made Visible

You cannot see respect directly. You see its expression. Listening. Preparation. Courtesy. Honouring commitments. And time. When I arrive when we agreed, I am saying: You mattered enough for me to plan. When an organization delivers when promised, it is saying: Your plans matter too. When a leader communicates early that a deadline will be missed, the leader is saying: I respect you enough not to leave you in uncertainty.

This is why punctuality belongs in a leadership book. It is not about clocks. It is about people.

Begin With One Clock

We do not need a national campaign before beginning. Choose one area. Meetings. Church programmes. Client appointments. Classes. Project deliveries. Family commitments. Calls. Start times. Do not attempt cultural revolution through speeches. Build one reliable habit. If the meeting says 9:00, begin at 9:00. The first week, some people may be absent. The second week, perhaps fewer. Eventually people learn that nine means nine. The environment begins teaching. Culture follows expectation. Expectation follows consistency.

And consistency begins with somebody deciding: The time we agreed will mean something.

Reflections for the Reader

How do I treat other people's time?

Do I see lateness as a weakness to correct—or something I've come to excuse?

What would my life look like if I honored every hour with intentionality?

Action Steps

Personal Practice: For the next seven days, record every commitment that has a specific time. Note when you actually arrive or deliver. Do not judge yourself immediately; first discover your real pattern.

Leadership Practice: Choose one recurring meeting you lead. Begin and end it according to the stated schedule for the next month. If a change is necessary, communicate it before people begin waiting.

Institutional Practice: Identify one service your organization provides with a stated completion time. Measure the actual completion time. The gap between the promise and reality is your starting point for improvement.

A Principle to Carry Forward

Punctuality is not obedience to a clock. It is respect for the people who organized their lives around your promise.

Final Reflection

Punctuality is often mistaken for perfectionism. But it is actually humility in action. It says: "You matter. This matters. I will be present."

Keeping time will not remove every uncertainty. It gives others a promise they can plan around—and a reason to trust the next one.

This is The Japanese Way.

Chapter 4

Excellence and Kaizen — Progress Through Purpose

"Excellence is not a finish line—it's a habitual direction."

— Najuna Saviour

There is a dangerous sentence in every organization. It usually sounds harmless. "It is good enough." Sometimes good enough is perfectly rational. Not every task requires perfection. Not every product needs the most expensive finish. Not every problem deserves endless analysis. But there is another kind of good enough. It appears when we know something could be done properly but decide that nobody will notice. A loose screw. An unanswered customer. An incorrect figure.

A dirty workspace. A poorly tested application. A document prepared carelessly. A product leaving the factory with a defect everyone hopes the customer will tolerate. A hospital process everyone knows causes unnecessary delay. A recurring mistake that has become so familiar that nobody asks why it continues. Eventually, good enough can become culture. And culture, repeated long enough, becomes reputation. Japan's experience offers another possibility. Not perfection. Improvement.

The Japanese word most associated with this idea is kaizen. It is often translated simply as continuous improvement. But the real power of Kaizen is not contained in the translation. It is contained in the question behind it: What can we make better today than it was yesterday?

Excellence Is Not Perfection

Before going further, we should separate two ideas. Perfection says: There must never be a mistake. Excellence says: We will take the work seriously, learn from mistakes and keep raising the standard. Perfection can become paralyzing. A writer refuses to publish because one more paragraph could always be improved. An entrepreneur never launches because another feature could always be added. A student spends so long trying to produce the perfect assignment that the deadline passes.

A leader becomes so afraid of failure that no experiment is allowed. Kaizen offers a different approach. Begin. Observe. Learn. Improve. Standardize what works. Then improve again. There is humility in this. It assumes that however good today's process is, tomorrow may reveal a better one. Toyota expresses this philosophy very simply in its Global Vision: "There is always a better way." That sentence may be one of the clearest descriptions of Kaizen.

The Small Improvement

We often imagine transformation dramatically. A new government. A new CEO. A new building. A new system. A new investor. A new machine. A new technology. There is value in major change. But many institutions do not fail because they lack one spectacular idea. They fail because hundreds of small problems are allowed to remain. Imagine a hospital where nurses spend five minutes searching for a particular item every time it is needed.

Five minutes may seem insignificant. But if the same problem happens twenty times a day, across several departments, throughout a year, enormous time disappears. Imagine a software company where deployment instructions exist only inside one developer's memory. Nothing appears wrong until that developer leaves. Imagine a shop where nobody knows the exact stock balance. A little money disappears here. A few products expire there.

Another customer is told something is unavailable when it is actually somewhere in the store. Each problem looks small. Together they

define the business. Kaizen begins by respecting small problems enough to address them.

Toyota and the Discipline of Improvement

The Toyota Production System has become one of the most studied approaches to manufacturing in the world. Toyota describes its objective as eliminating waste, reducing lead times, delivering high quality and making work easier for workers. The company says that employees throughout the organization implement daily incremental Kaizen. That word matters: daily. Not once every five years when consultants arrive. Not only after a crisis. Not only when senior management launches a transformation programme. Daily.

Toyota's system rests particularly on two well-known principles: jidoka and Just-in-Time. They may sound technical. But both contain leadership lessons far beyond factories.

Jidoka - Stop When Something Is Wrong

Toyota describes jidoka loosely as automation with a human touch. Its central principle is that when an abnormality or defect is detected, production should be capable of stopping so the problem can be addressed rather than allowing defective work to continue downstream. Think about how different that mindset is from: "We know there is a problem, but keep going." Many organizations operate exactly that way. A project has an obvious design flaw. Keep going.

Financial records are becoming unreliable. Keep going. Customers are repeatedly reporting the same problem. Keep going. A construction mistake is discovered. Cover it and keep going. An employee realizes data are wrong. Do not embarrass management. Keep going. We often fear stopping because stopping appears unproductive. But sometimes continuing is much more expensive. The further a defect moves through a system, the more costly it may become to correct.

A mistake discovered while writing software may take minutes to fix. The same mistake discovered after thousands of customers depend on

that software may become a crisis. A construction measurement corrected before concrete is poured costs little. Correct it after the building rises, and the consequences are very different. Jidoka therefore contains a powerful principle: Problems become more dangerous when systems teach people to hide them rather than stop for them.

Give People Permission to Notice

Toyota's production approach includes mechanisms through which workers can signal abnormalities so that problems receive attention rather than simply move down the line. The specific manufacturing mechanism matters less to us than the philosophy. The person closest to the work must have some ability to say: Something is wrong. This is a leadership issue. If an employee sees a serious problem but believes speaking will result in punishment, silence becomes rational.

If a junior developer discovers a security flaw but leadership only wants to hear that the product is ready, the organization has created danger. If a nurse sees unsafe practice but authority cannot be questioned, patients may pay the cost. If an accountant sees strange transactions but raising them threatens employment, governance has already failed. Excellence requires truth to travel. Kaizen cannot survive where people are required to pretend.

Just-in-Time - Not More, but What Is Needed

The second major pillar of Toyota's production system is Just-in-Time. Toyota describes it as producing only what is needed, when it is needed, and in the amount needed, with processes synchronized to reduce unnecessary stock and waste. Again, we do not need to operate a car factory to learn something from this. Waste exists everywhere. Unused inventory. Duplicate work. Meetings nobody needs. Reports nobody reads. Software features customers never requested. Approvals that add no value.

People waiting for signatures. Employees entering the same information into several systems. Buildings constructed but poorly

used. Equipment purchased without plans for maintenance. Money tied up in items that do not move. Entrepreneurs sometimes mistake having more for being better. A bigger office. More employees. More stock. More features. More branches. More equipment. But growth without process can simply produce larger waste. Excellence asks another question: What actually creates value?

Muda, Mura and Muri

Toyota's current description of its production philosophy explicitly speaks of reducing: muda - waste, mura - unevenness or irregularity, and muri - overburden or unreasonable demands. These three ideas deserve attention because they prevent us from misunderstanding Japanese efficiency as simply working harder. Sometimes efficiency means working less foolishly. Consider a worker forced to walk repeatedly between two poorly arranged rooms. They may be working extremely hard. But the system is wasting movement.

Consider employees overwhelmed at month-end because nobody distributed work properly during the month. That is not necessarily laziness. It may be unevenness. Consider an employee routinely given more tasks than a human being can reasonably complete. Demanding greater commitment does not solve the underlying overburden. It may merely exhaust the employee. This gives Kaizen an important human dimension. The question is not: How do we squeeze more out of people? It can instead be:

How do we design work so people can perform better with less unnecessary struggle? That is a very different philosophy.

Excellence Must Make Work Better Too

Sakichi Toyoda's early work on looms is part of the origin story Toyota itself gives for the development of jidoka. Toyota recounts that Sakichi watched his mother working hard at weaving and sought ways to make the work easier. That desire contributed to innovations that eventually enabled looms to stop when something went wrong rather than requiring constant supervision. There is something

profound here. Innovation was not initially described only as increasing production.

It was also about reducing unnecessary human burden. That gives us an important test for technology. Whenever we introduce a new system, ask: Does it actually improve people's work? Or does it merely digitize a bad process? A poorly designed paper system does not automatically become excellent because we create an app for it. Sometimes technology merely makes confusion electronic. The real question is: Did we improve the process?

Excellence Is Designed Into the Process

Quality should not depend entirely on somebody inspecting the finished product and hoping to catch every defect. Toyota's jidoka philosophy emphasizes identifying abnormalities during the process and preventing defective products from moving forward. That principle applies almost everywhere. A publisher should not depend only on the final proofreader. Good research practices should exist while the manuscript is being written. A software company should not depend only on the customer discovering bugs.

Testing should happen during development. A construction company should not wait until the building is complete to discover whether key measurements were wrong. A hospital should not wait for patient harm before examining unsafe procedures. An accountant should not wait until year-end before realizing the books have been unreliable all year. Quality is strongest when it is built into the way work happens. Not added at the end.

The Five S's

Another Japanese-origin improvement approach that travelled far beyond manufacturing is usually described as 5S: Sort, Set, Shine, Standardize and Sustain. The language is deceptively simple. Sort what belongs from what does not. Arrange what is needed so it can be found. Keep the work environment clean and functional. Develop agreed standards. Then maintain them. You could dismiss this as

housekeeping. Until you consider what disorder costs. A missing medical item during an emergency.

A document nobody can locate. Tools stored differently every day. Expired stock mixed with usable stock. Files named inconsistently. Passwords known only to one employee. Equipment whose condition nobody checks. Inventory with no clear location. A cluttered physical or digital workspace creates invisible friction. 5S asks organizations to confront that friction. And this is where the story becomes particularly important for an African reader.

Because we do not have to imagine what would happen if Japanese improvement principles reached Uganda. They already have.

When Kaizen Reached Ugandan Hospitals

For me, this is one of the most important discoveries in researching this book. I began with stories from Duku about Japan. But while researching Kaizen, I found that some of these ideas had already crossed from Japanese industry into Uganda's health sector. Uganda's Ministry of Health has formally adopted the 5S-Continuous Quality Improvement (Kaizen)-Total Quality Management approach as part of health-service quality improvement.

JICA describes the approach as a means of improving health-service quality, safety and management in cooperation with Uganda's Ministry of Health. This is not a motivational seminar. It is health policy. JICA reports that the approach was rolled out across Uganda's Regional Referral Hospitals through technical cooperation projects, with the aim of improving working environments, management, quality, safety and ultimately patient care.

In 2021, Uganda's Ministry of Health and JICA launched a further five-year project focused specifically on establishing a stronger patient-safety culture through 5S-CQI-TQM in regional referral hospitals and other target hospitals. [17] Think about what that means. A philosophy associated with Japanese manufacturing travelled thousands of kilometres. It entered African hospitals. It was adapted.

It became part of Uganda's own quality-improvement framework. That is precisely the kind of cultural exchange this book is arguing for.

Not copying Japan. Learning, adapting and applying.

Uganda Did Not Become Japan

When Uganda adopted these methods, doctors did not become Japanese. Hospitals did not stop being Ugandan. The health system did not abandon local realities. The principle travelled. The context remained. This distinction may be one of the most important arguments in The Japanese Way. We often resist learning because we confuse learning with imitation. We say: "That works in Japan. This is Africa." Sometimes that statement contains wisdom. Contexts differ. Budgets differ. Infrastructure differs.

History differs. Institutions differ. Social relationships differ. But sometimes the statement becomes an excuse to avoid examining whether the underlying principle might still be useful. Uganda's health sector demonstrates another possibility. Take the principle. Translate it. Test it. Adapt it. Make it ours.

JICA's account describes the approach as having been rolled out across Uganda's regional referral hospitals. It is evidence of institutional adoption; it does not establish that every hospital achieved the same results. [17] At that point, the idea is no longer simply "Japanese." It has become part of Uganda's own institutional learning.

This Is What Cultural Exchange Should Look Like

Sometimes international cooperation is discussed as money moving from one country to another. But knowledge can be more enduring than money. Money may purchase equipment. Knowledge can change how equipment is managed. Money can construct a building. Knowledge can change how that building operates. Money can purchase software. Knowledge can improve the processes the software supports. Money may solve today's shortage. Institutional learning can reduce tomorrow's waste.

The most valuable question in cooperation may therefore not always be: How much assistance did we receive? It may also be: What capability remained after the project ended? That is a Kaizen question.

From Uganda to Africa

Uganda is not an isolated example. In 2017, JICA and NEPAD, the predecessor of AUDA-NEPAD, launched the Africa Kaizen Initiative, designed as a ten-year effort to spread Kaizen approaches across African countries while explicitly respecting each country's ownership of the process. [9] Notice that final principle: ownership. That word matters. The purpose is not: Japan tells Africa how to work. It is closer to:

A useful management philosophy travels, and African institutions determine how to apply it to their realities. That is the model this book should defend. Africa must remain the author of its own development. Learning from another society does not surrender authorship. It may strengthen it.

Made in Africa

This leads to a question I believe African leaders and entrepreneurs should ask seriously: What would it take for "Made in Africa" to communicate unquestioned confidence in quality? Not charity. Not patriotism alone. Quality. A customer somewhere in Kampala, Nairobi, Kigali, Lagos, Johannesburg, London or Tokyo sees a product made in Africa and thinks: I trust this. That reputation will not be built primarily through slogans. It will be built one product at a time.

One factory at a time. One developer at a time. One hotel room at a time. One agricultural shipment at a time. One pharmaceutical batch at a time. One customer interaction at a time. Reputation is cumulative. Japan itself did not always possess the global manufacturing reputation it now enjoys. Reputation is constructed.

And what has been constructed somewhere can teach those building elsewhere.

Monozukuri - More Than Making Things

Japan has another useful idea often written as monozukuri. It literally relates to making things, but Japanese public institutions use it more broadly to refer to craftsmanship and manufacturing capability. In this book, monozukuri draws our attention to the skill, care and practical knowledge involved in making things well. The useful question is how that care becomes visible in ordinary work. But the lesson for us should not become: Japan makes good things.

The deeper question is: What happens when making something well becomes a source of dignity? Consider how differently a society might function if craftsmanship carried honour. The carpenter takes pride in a joint nobody may ever inspect closely. The developer takes pride in code the customer will never see. The mechanic returns every bolt properly. The cleaner regards cleanliness as professional work. The graphic designer checks alignment.

The chef cares about consistency on an ordinary Tuesday, not only when an important visitor arrives. The civil engineer thinks about the road after the ribbon-cutting ceremony. Excellence is often invisible. But eventually its consequences become visible.

The Customer Should Not Be the Quality Inspector

There is a damaging business model that operates like this: Produce quickly. Sell. Wait to see whether the customer notices. If they complain, fix it. If they do not, keep the money. This may generate short-term profit. It destroys long-term trust. A strong quality culture reverses the logic. The producer should detect as many problems as possible before the customer has to. This principle is especially important in Africa's growing technology ecosystem.

An entrepreneur may think: We will launch now and fix everything later. There is wisdom in not waiting for perfection. But "minimum viable product" should not mean: minimum responsible product.

Some things cannot be postponed. Security. Data protection. Financial accuracy. Safety. Backups. Integrity. Honesty about what the product can actually do. Kaizen means improvement after launch. It does not excuse negligence before launch.

A Message to the Entrepreneur

Your company does not need Toyota's budget to practice Kaizen. Begin with questions. Which customer complaint happens most often? Which task consumes unnecessary time every week? Which item is repeatedly misplaced? Where does money leak? Which process depends entirely on one person? Which service is consistently late? Which information is entered twice? Which product defect repeatedly returns? Which meeting produces no action? Choose one. Do not announce a company-wide transformation. Improve the process.

Measure what changed. If it works, make the improvement standard. Then find the next problem. This is how small organizations become disciplined organizations.

A Message to the Software Developer

Software development may be one of the easiest places to understand Kaizen. No serious software product is truly "finished." Versions improve. Bugs are corrected. User feedback reveals unexpected behaviour. Performance is optimized. Security evolves. Interfaces improve. Technical debt is reduced. A developer therefore already lives inside continuous improvement. The challenge is whether that mindset extends beyond code. Can project estimation improve? Can documentation improve? Can backups improve? Can deployment improve? Can client communication improve?

Can testing improve? Can code review improve? Can onboarding another developer improve? The strongest technical teams are not those that never experience problems. They are those capable of learning faster from them.

A Message to the Student

Students sometimes interpret excellence as getting the highest mark. Marks matter. But education becomes much more powerful when excellence means improving the person who produces the work. Suppose you receive 62 percent. The useful question is not only: Why didn't I get 80? Ask: What did I misunderstand? Where was my reasoning weak? Did I begin too late? Was my research poor? Did I understand the question? What will I do differently next time?

That turns assessment into feedback rather than judgment. The student practicing Kaizen does not need to become perfect next semester. The student needs to become better. Repeated enough times, improvement can produce excellence.

A Message to the Professional

Do not wait for annual performance reviews to ask whether your work can improve. At the end of a significant task, ask: What took too long? What caused confusion? What mistake repeated? What did the client ask twice? What could have been prepared earlier? What should I document before I forget? Professional growth accelerates when experience is converted into lessons. Ten years of employment does not automatically produce ten years of improvement.

A person can repeat the same year ten times. Experience becomes valuable when it produces learning.

A Message to the Leader

Leaders have a special responsibility in a Kaizen culture. They must make it safe enough to identify problems. If every problem is treated as evidence that someone is incompetent, employees learn to hide them. Then leadership receives perfect reports from broken systems. A strong leader can hear: This process is failing without immediately asking: Who do I punish? The first question should often be: Why is it failing? There may ultimately be individual accountability.

But improvement requires understanding before blame. Leaders must also distinguish between standards and ego. A process should not remain bad simply because the leader invented it. The goal is not to protect yesterday's decision. The goal is to improve tomorrow's result.

Standardize - Then Improve Again

There is an apparent contradiction inside continuous improvement. If everything is always changing, how can an organization become stable? The answer is standardization. When an improvement works, it becomes the current standard. Everyone learns the better way. Then that standard becomes the starting point for another improvement. Without standards, Kaizen becomes chaos. If five employees all perform the same task in five completely different ways, it becomes difficult to understand what is actually improving.

A standard gives the organization something to measure. This does not mean suppressing creativity. It means distinguishing creativity from inconsistency.

The Difficult Fifth S: Sustain

Of the five S's, the last may be the hardest. Sustain. Many organizations can clean an office before an important visitor comes. Many can launch a quality campaign. Many can hold a workshop. Many can install a new system. The real question comes six months later. Is the workspace still organized? Is the system still being used? Are people still measuring? Are managers still checking? Did the enthusiasm become habit?

The difference between an event and a culture is often sustain. This may be especially relevant to development programmes. A project can look excellent while donors, consultants or senior leadership are watching. What remains after attention moves elsewhere? Kaizen ultimately has to belong to the people doing the work. Otherwise improvement ends when supervision ends.

Improvement Without Purpose Can Become Obsession

There is another danger. If "better" becomes an end in itself, people can improve things that do not matter. A company spends months perfecting a feature customers do not want. A government develops ever more complicated reporting systems instead of improving the service being reported. A manager creates sophisticated performance dashboards but never speaks to customers. A student perfects formatting while the argument remains weak. Excellence requires purpose. The question is not:

Can this be improved? Almost everything can. The better question is: Which improvement creates meaningful value? This is why Kaizen needs direction. Continuous improvement without purpose becomes continuous activity.

The Courage to Stop

Sometimes improvement does not mean adding something. It means stopping. Stop the meeting nobody needs. Stop producing the report nobody reads. Stop offering the product customers no longer value. Stop requiring three signatures where one accountable approval is enough. Stop maintaining software nobody uses. Stop printing what can safely remain digital. Stop pretending an old process remains necessary merely because it has always existed. Improvement can subtract.

In fact, some of the greatest efficiency gains come from removing unnecessary work.

Africa Does Not Need Another Imported Slogan

One of my concerns while writing this book is that ideas like Kaizen can become fashionable words. A conference happens. People receive branded notebooks. The word appears in speeches. Photographs are taken. Then ordinary life continues unchanged. Africa does not need the vocabulary of Kaizen. Africa needs the practice of improvement. And Uganda's health experience makes this particularly instructive.

If 5S is simply written on hospital walls but instruments remain impossible to find, nothing has changed. If Kaizen appears in policy documents but workers cannot identify and solve problems, nothing has changed. If Total Quality Management becomes another acronym understood only by consultants, nothing has changed. The value of an idea is demonstrated in operation.

What Japan Can Learn Too

This book must never suggest that wisdom moves only in one direction. Japan has extraordinary strengths in manufacturing, organization and systems. Africa possesses strengths that highly structured societies can sometimes struggle to reproduce. Improvisation. Community. Human flexibility. Informal networks of support. The ability to operate under uncertainty. Entrepreneurial creativity when resources are scarce. Social warmth. Rapid adaptation.

A Ugandan entrepreneur who keeps a business functioning through electricity problems, supply disruption, limited capital and changing customer circumstances is practicing a form of resilience that deserves study too. The question is therefore not whether Japan or Africa is superior. The more useful question is: What happens when strengths meet? Japanese process discipline combined with African adaptability. Japanese continuous improvement combined with African entrepreneurial energy. Japanese attention to quality combined with African creativity.

That is a much more interesting future than cultural imitation.

Excellence Is a Decision Made Repeatedly

Most people will never operate a Shinkansen. Most will never manage a Toyota factory. Most will never run a national health system. But everyone makes something. A report. A meal. An application. A business. A lesson. A sermon. A building. A customer experience. A policy. A song. A relationship. A reputation. The principle travels. Do the work deliberately. Notice problems. Correct them. Learn. Create a better standard. Repeat.

There is no final day when the person practicing Kaizen says: Now I have arrived. Nothing needs improvement again. That would contradict the philosophy. Excellence is not a destination. It is a relationship with work.

Uganda Is Already Part of the Story

When I began thinking about The Japanese Way, I imagined Japan on one side and Africa on the other. Japan had something to teach. Africa had something to learn. Research complicated that picture. Uganda is already inside the story. Japanese-origin quality practices have already entered Ugandan hospitals. Ugandan health professionals have already adapted them. The Ministry of Health has already incorporated them into its own frameworks.

Across the continent, African institutions are already engaging with Kaizen through an initiative built around local ownership. So this book is not asking: Could Africa someday learn from Japan? That process is already happening. The more important question is: How intentionally will we learn, adapt, improve and eventually create systems that others come to learn from us? That is the future worth pursuing. The ultimate ambition cannot be permanent apprenticeship.

One day, others should travel to Kampala, Kigali, Nairobi, Accra, Lagos, Johannesburg, Dar es Salaam and elsewhere because African institutions have developed systems worth studying. Learning should eventually produce contribution.

From Kaizen to Confidence

Imagine the cumulative effect. A business improves one process. Then another. Then another. Employees begin identifying waste without being told. Customers notice increased consistency. Quality becomes predictable. The company becomes trusted. Another African company does the same. Then an industry. Then institutions. Slowly the phrase Made in Africa acquires another layer of meaning. Not because somebody launched a branding campaign. Because millions

of small improvements made the promise believable. That is how reputation is built.

Quietly. Repeatedly. Over time. Perhaps this is one of Japan's strongest lessons for the world. Greatness does not always arrive dramatically. Sometimes it is simply yesterday's work, made a little better today. And tomorrow, better again.

Reflections for the Reader

Where have I settled for "good enough" in my work or character?

Do I wait for motivation—or build better habits?

What would improve if I focused on small daily progress?

Action Steps

Personal Practice: Choose one repeated activity in your life - your morning routine, study process, financial records, writing, exercise, communication or project management. Identify one source of waste or friction. Improve only that part this week.

Leadership Practice: Ask your team one question: "What makes your work unnecessarily difficult?" Do not defend the existing process. Listen first. Choose one practical problem and remove it.

Institutional Practice: Select one recurring service or workflow. Document the current process from beginning to end. Identify delay, duplication, unnecessary movement, repeated errors and unclear responsibility. Make one measurable improvement, standardize it, and review the result after thirty days.

A Principle to Carry Forward

Excellence is not doing everything perfectly. It is refusing to become comfortable with problems we have the ability to improve.

Final Reflection

You don't need to transform the world in one leap. Begin with one improvement whose value you can see, and return to it with purpose.

The work may attract little applause. Its meaning is in the people served, the waste prevented, and the standard you leave for those who follow.

This is The Japanese Way.

Part II

Lessons in Action

Chapter 5

Education That Builds Nations

> *"I believe that education, therefore, is a process of living and not a preparation for future living."*
>
> — John Dewey

A nation can build schools without necessarily building character. It can increase enrolment. Expand universities. Produce graduates. Award certificates. Construct laboratories. Introduce computers. Raise examination scores. All of these things matter. But another question remains: What kind of person is education producing? Can the graduate work with others? Can they take responsibility without being watched? Can they care for shared property? Can they solve a problem instead of only describing it? Can they disagree respectfully?

Can they lead when nobody gives them a title? Can they complete ordinary duties with dignity? Can they recognize that their actions affect a larger community? Education becomes nation-building when knowledge begins to shape behaviour. And this brings me back to the classroom that started this book.

The Lesson Before the Lecture

When Duku Micheal entered that classroom in Japan, the academic lesson had not yet begun. Everyone was seated. Everyone was silent. They were waiting. Then came the words: "Now that the missing student has arrived, we can begin." What interests me now is that the most lasting lesson Duku carried from that day may not have been whatever academic subject the lecturer eventually taught. It was what happened before the lecture.

No examination had been announced. No notes were dictated. No definition was written on the board. Yet education was taking place. The environment communicated: Your presence matters. Your time affects others. You belong to a group. Membership carries responsibility. Duku changed his behaviour. That is education. Not merely information entering the mind. But understanding entering behaviour.

When the School Becomes a Small Society

One of the most interesting features of Japanese schooling is an area of the curriculum known as Tokubetsu Katsudo, commonly shortened to Tokkatsu, or "Special Activities." Japan's Ministry of Education describes Special Activities as including classroom activities, student council activities, club activities at elementary level, and school events. These activities are intended to help children participate practically in group life, address shared problems and develop themselves as members of a community.

The idea behind this deserves attention. The school is not viewed only as a place where children receive lessons. It can also function as a small society. Children therefore do not merely learn about cooperation. They have opportunities to cooperate. They do not merely read about responsibility. They receive responsibilities. They do not merely memorize definitions of leadership. They take turns leading. They do not merely hear that common spaces should be respected.

They participate in maintaining those spaces. This distinction is profound. A person can know the definition of responsibility and still be irresponsible. Character requires practice.

You Cannot Teach Responsibility Only on a Blackboard

Imagine teaching swimming entirely through lectures. The teacher draws water on the board. Explains buoyancy. Defines strokes. Shows diagrams. Sets an examination. The student scores 95 percent. Then you place the student in water. Something important is missing. Practice. Many aspects of character work the same way. You can

teach: teamwork, leadership, cleanliness, responsibility, service, self-management, citizenship, respect. But eventually students need environments in which those values become actions.

Tokkatsu is interesting precisely because the activities are ordinary. There is no dramatic leadership conference. Children participate in the daily functioning of school life. And ordinary repetition can be one of education's most powerful teachers.

The Classroom Does Not Clean Itself

Visitors to Japanese schools are often surprised to see students participating in cleaning. This is not merely an internet story. Japanese education materials describe school cleaning as an opportunity for students to care for their shared environment. The specific duties should reflect children's ages, abilities and safety. [4, 5] At first glance, cleaning has little to do with mathematics, science or language. Yet consider what a child might learn.

The floor I use is partly my responsibility. The room does not become clean by magic. Someone's labour produces the environment I enjoy. Shared property deserves care. No useful task automatically becomes beneath me because I am educated. Cleaning then becomes more than cleaning. It becomes social education.

What Happens When Somebody Else Always Cleans Up?

There is a subtle danger when people grow up believing that responsibility for shared spaces always belongs to somebody else. Drop the paper. Someone will collect it. Damage the desk. It belongs to the institution. Leave the room disorganized. There is a cleaner. Waste water. It is not my bill. Ignore broken equipment. Maintenance will deal with it. This attitude eventually travels. From school. To university. To workplaces. To public spaces. To institutions.

To national property. The problem is not whether professional cleaners exist. Professional cleaning is legitimate work and often essential. The deeper question is whether the existence of a cleaner removes my responsibility not to create unnecessary disorder.

Education should teach both respect for the person who cleans and respect for the environment being cleaned. That is a different mindset.

Lunch Can Also Be Education

Japan's school lunch system offers another example. Japanese government materials describe school lunch not only as nutritional provision but as an educational activity. Students commonly take turns carrying and serving meals, and the lunch programme is connected with food education, hygiene, manners and healthy eating habits. Again, the activity is ordinary. Serve food. Eat together. Clean afterward. But ordinary activities carry social lessons. Wait for others. Handle food responsibly. Serve classmates. Take your turn.

Clean after yourself. Think about nutrition. Recognize that meals require preparation and labour. A society is partly formed through such repetitions. Children are constantly learning what normal behaviour looks like. The question is whether we design that learning intentionally.

Leadership for One Day

Japanese school life also includes rotating classroom duties. Special Activities materials describe classroom responsibilities as opportunities for practical participation. Rotating suitable duties allows more children to experience responsibility, cooperation and leadership. [4, 5] This interests me because leadership is distributed. The same child is not permanently "the leader." Responsibility rotates. Today you may lead. Tomorrow you follow someone else. That teaches something important about authority. Leadership is a function before it is a status.

You have responsibility for a period. Then somebody else does. That is remarkably different from teaching children that leadership belongs primarily to the most powerful, loudest or permanently appointed person. A healthy society needs people who can both lead and cooperate.

The Student Council Is Not Just Decoration

Many schools around the world have prefects, student councils, class representatives or club leaders. The question is what students actually learn through those structures. If the title exists only for prestige, the lesson may become: Leadership means status. If the role carries real responsibility, another lesson becomes possible: Leadership means service. If a student representative learns to listen to classmates, organize activity, communicate concerns and account for decisions, something valuable is happening.

They are rehearsing citizenship. The school becomes a laboratory for institutional life. This is one reason Tokkatsu is bigger than any single activity. The philosophy is that students can learn to participate in society by first participating meaningfully in the smaller society of the school.

Education for Living

Japan has used the expression ikiru chikara, commonly translated along the lines of "competencies for living" or "zest for living," in describing a broader educational aim that goes beyond academic knowledge alone. The Special Activities approach connects classroom learning with practical participation, discussion and cooperation in the life of the school. [4, 5] That does not mean academics are unimportant. Mathematics matters. Science matters. Literacy matters. Technology matters. History matters. Examinations have legitimate functions.

But knowledge exists inside a person. And the person carrying the knowledge will eventually enter a family, company, laboratory, government office, hospital, classroom, engineering site or community. What kind of person carries the knowledge therefore matters too.

Character Should Not Compete With Intelligence

There is sometimes an unnecessary argument in education. Should schools teach academic excellence or character? The answer should be:

Both. We should not lower academic standards in the name of character. And we should not produce brilliant minds incapable of responsibility. The engineer needs technical competence. But integrity matters when calculations affect people's lives. The doctor needs medical knowledge. But responsibility matters when patients depend upon judgment. The software developer needs technical skill.

But ethics matter when systems store people's money or personal information. The accountant needs numerical competence. But honesty matters when entrusted with funds. The journalist needs communication skills. But truth matters. The entrepreneur needs commercial intelligence. But reliability matters. Knowledge gives people capability. Character influences what they do with it.

Japan Teaches Morality Formally Too

Japan does not rely solely on cleaning and lunch duties to communicate values. Moral education is formally part of the national curriculum. The Ministry of Education currently identifies Morality as a Special Subject at elementary and lower-secondary levels, with lesson examples dealing with themes such as friendship and trust, mutual understanding and tolerance, family life, respect for law and public-mindedness. [18]

Importantly, Japanese education policy has also emphasized moving toward moral education that involves thinking and discussion, including moral issues that may not have only one obvious answer. That matters. Character education should not merely produce children who repeat: "Honesty is good." "Respect is important." "Responsibility matters." The more difficult educational task is helping young people reason when values conflict. What do you do when telling the truth may hurt a friend?

What does responsibility require when everyone else is cheating? What does loyalty mean when a leader is wrong? What does respect mean when you disagree? What do you do when obeying a rule produces an unjust result? Maturity involves judgment. Education should help develop it.

Character Is Not Blind Obedience

This distinction is especially important when discussing Japan. Discipline can easily be misunderstood as obedience. Cooperation can become conformity. Respect can become silence. A society does not need citizens who simply follow instructions. It needs people capable of responsible judgment. A healthy educational model should therefore help students become cooperative without becoming intellectually passive. The best classroom is not one in which nobody questions anything.

It is one in which students learn how to question responsibly. How to disagree without destruction. How to participate without losing individuality. How to respect a group without surrendering conscience. This is why I prefer the language of character and responsibility to the language of obedience. A leader who cannot think independently is dangerous. So is a leader who cannot cooperate. Education must develop both.

The Classroom Is Practicing the Future

Picture two classrooms. In the first, students learn that common property belongs to nobody. Nobody takes responsibility unless the teacher is watching. Leadership belongs only to appointed prefects. Rules matter only when punishment is likely. Cleaning is someone else's job. Time is flexible whenever there are no consequences. Group work means one serious student completes everything. Mistakes should be hidden. Now imagine these habits surviving into adulthood. The office will look familiar.

The institution will look familiar. The government department will look familiar. The company will look familiar. Now picture another classroom. Students learn: If we use it, we care for it. If we are responsible, we complete it. If something goes wrong, we discuss it. If we share a task, everyone contributes. If I lead today, I serve the group. If somebody else leads tomorrow, I cooperate. Time matters because other people's lives are involved.

Imagine those habits surviving into adulthood. Education quietly becomes institutional development.

Nations Are Built Long Before People Enter Parliament

When we discuss national leadership, attention naturally moves toward presidents, ministers, parliamentarians, chief executives and senior officials. But the habits those leaders carry were formed long before their appointments. Some were formed at home. Some in school. Some in religious communities. Some among peers. Some through early employment. By the time someone reaches national leadership, society has already spent decades educating that person. This means leadership development cannot begin only when someone becomes important.

Education is one of society's earliest leadership institutions. A child learning to take responsibility for a classroom is not running a ministry. But something is beginning. A student learning to account for a group assignment is not managing a company. But something is beginning. A teenager learning that public property deserves care is not managing national infrastructure. But something is beginning. Culture grows before authority arrives.

An African Question: What Are We Measuring?

Across our societies, examination results understandably receive enormous attention. A child passes. A child fails. Schools are compared. Parents celebrate grades. Students compete for university places. Academic achievement matters. But imagine a school producing excellent examination results while students gradually learn: to cheat if they can avoid detection, to disrespect people doing manual work, to arrive late without concern, to destroy shared property, to avoid responsibility, to pursue titles without service.

Would we call that education completely successful? Perhaps our educational scorecards need more questions. Can students cooperate? Can they communicate? Can they solve problems? Can they care for a common environment? Can they organize themselves? Can they

manage disagreement? Can they lead? Can they serve? Can they be trusted? Some of these are difficult to reduce to a percentage. That does not make them unimportant.

Education Must Connect the Head and the Hand

There is another challenge worth considering. Sometimes education accidentally communicates that the more educated you become, the further you should move away from practical work. Success begins to mean: Someone else carries. Someone else cleans. Someone else repairs. Someone else works with their hands. But societies need dignity attached to useful work. Japan's school-cleaning practices offer an interesting symbolic challenge to this hierarchy. The academically gifted child still participates. The future executive still participates.

The future engineer still participates. The future public official still participates. The activity says: Education does not make ordinary responsibility beneath you. That idea could travel very far.

What If Universities Taught Institutional Life?

The same question should extend beyond primary and secondary schools. Universities spend years developing specialized knowledge. But university is also where many young adults first experience substantial independence. What institutional habits are being formed there? Can students organize serious associations? Can they manage budgets transparently? Can they conduct meetings? Can they collaborate across differences? Can they complete research honestly? Can they respect intellectual property? Can they disagree without violence? Can they design projects?

Can they serve communities? Can they build something that continues after they graduate? A university should not merely release individuals carrying degrees. It can release people who already have experience building and maintaining institutions.

A Message to the Student

Your education is larger than your transcript. Do not misunderstand me. Work seriously for your grades. Master your field. Know your profession. But also watch what is happening to you while you study. Are you more dependable? Can people trust you in group work? Do you manage your time better than you did last year? Can you communicate more clearly? Can you accept correction? Can you research honestly? Do you leave shared spaces better?

Can you finish what you begin? Can you work with somebody you do not particularly like? Those qualities may never appear on your certificate. Your future colleagues will discover them quickly.

A Message to the Parent

Parents also shape educational culture. If a child is never allowed to carry responsibility because: "They are too young," "They are studying," "Someone else will do it," we may protect them from the very experiences that develop competence. Responsibility should obviously match age and safety. But children need real contribution. Set the table. Organize something. Care for something. Help somebody. Complete a household task. Manage a small budget. Take responsibility when something is forgotten.

A family can become a child's first school of leadership.

A Message to the Teacher

Teachers carry extraordinary influence because children learn from what teachers normalize. If the teacher teaches punctuality but routinely arrives late, students receive two lessons. If the teacher teaches integrity but manipulates marks, two lessons. If the teacher demands respect but humiliates students, two lessons. Children are excellent observers of contradiction. Character education therefore begins with adult character. A school culture cannot sustainably teach responsibility through posters while adults model irresponsibility.

Students do not only learn the curriculum. They learn the institution.

A Message to the Entrepreneur

Why should an entrepreneur care about education reform? Because today's classrooms contain tomorrow's employees, customers, managers and founders. Businesses frequently complain: Young employees lack initiative. They wait to be told everything. They struggle to collaborate. They do not communicate problems early. They expect promotion without responsibility. Even where such complaints are exaggerated, businesses should ask another question: What are we doing to continue education inside the workplace? A company is also a learning institution.

New staff learn what truly matters by watching. If quality is praised but poor work is tolerated, they learn the real standard. If initiative is requested but every independent decision is punished, they learn not to think. If leadership talks about teamwork but promotions reward only individual visibility, people learn competition. Organizations educate continuously. The question is whether they educate intentionally.

A Message to the Leader

Leaders should ask: What does our institution teach people simply by requiring them to live inside it? A badly designed institution can educate good people into bad habits. Employees learn that deadlines do not matter. They learn that seniority matters more than competence. They learn that problems should be concealed. They learn that equipment belongs to nobody. They learn that meetings begin when the most powerful person arrives.

They learn that accountability flows downward while privilege flows upward. Then leadership wonders why culture is poor. Institutions are classrooms. Policies teach. Incentives teach. Consequences teach. Examples teach. What leadership tolerates becomes curriculum.

Japanese Education Travels to Egypt

Perhaps one of the strongest demonstrations that Japanese educational ideas can cross cultures is occurring not in Japan but in Africa.

Japan and Egypt launched the Egypt-Japan Education Partnership in 2016. Through the programme, Egypt introduced Japanese-style Special Activities, or Tokkatsu, in Egypt-Japan Schools beginning in 2018, with activities including classroom discussions, rotating daily responsibilities and student cleaning. JICA says the aim is to strengthen abilities such as cooperation, self-management and problem-solving alongside academic development.

The cooperation did not assume that Egyptian children should simply become Japanese children. JICA specifically describes the approach as being adapted to local social and cultural contexts. This is important for The Japanese Way. Again we see a pattern: Learn. Adapt. Own. The idea crosses a border. The country receiving it interprets it. The practice changes as necessary. Learning does not require cultural surrender.

Africa Does Not Need Japanese Schools

Africa needs strong African schools. Ugandan schools should remain Ugandan. Egyptian schools should remain Egyptian. Ghanaian schools should remain Ghanaian. Kenyan schools should remain Kenyan. The purpose of looking at Japan is not to import uniforms, rituals and procedures indiscriminately. The purpose is to identify principles. For example: Shared responsibility. How should that look in Kampala? Student participation. How should that work in Kigali? Character alongside academics. How should it work in Accra?

Respect for shared environments. What does that look like in Nairobi? Leadership practice for young people. What form should that take in Lagos? The principle can travel. The implementation belongs to the people receiving it.

And Japan Can Still Learn

The exchange should not be one-directional.

JICA itself has recently emphasized mutual learning and noted something interesting: while Tokkatsu has been adapted abroad, its implementation in Japan can place burdens on teachers and its purpose is not always fully understood. JICA has suggested that lessons emerging from partner countries may also contribute back to Japanese education.

That is a beautiful correction to the idea that one country is always teacher and another always student. The teacher can learn from the student. The exporter of an idea can rediscover the idea through the people who adapt it. That is what genuine exchange looks like. Japan has no monopoly on educational wisdom. Africa does not arrive empty-handed.

What Africa Brings to the Classroom

African educational traditions and communities possess strengths worth protecting. Intergenerational learning. Oral storytelling. Community responsibility. Respect for elders. Practical apprenticeship. Shared child-rearing. Music. Collective celebration. Learning through participation. Resourcefulness under constraint. In many communities, education existed long before the modern classroom. A young person learned farming by farming. Craft by observing craftsmen. Community responsibility through participation. History through story. Values through family and community life. Modern schooling should not require forgetting all of this.

The interesting future may be a synthesis: academic excellence, technology, scientific thinking, Japanese-style responsibility where useful, and African traditions of community and human connection. That would not be Japanese education. It would be our own education strengthened by intelligent learning from elsewhere.

Education and the Dignity of Service

One idea keeps returning throughout this chapter. Service. The child serves lunch. The class cleans together. Students rotate responsibilities. Older pupils sometimes support younger ones. Leadership appears as contribution. What would happen if education helped restore the dignity of service? Imagine a generation that did not immediately ask: What title do I receive? but also: What responsibility comes with it? Imagine graduates who did not interpret leadership as exemption from ordinary duties.

Imagine political leadership understood not primarily as access to privilege but as increased obligation. Imagine business leaders who believed authority increased responsibility rather than reduced it. Those ideas do not begin in cabinet rooms. They can begin in classrooms.

A Degree Is Not the End of Education

There is also a lesson for adults. Sometimes we treat education as a phase. You study. Graduate. Receive a certificate. Finish. Kaizen rejects that understanding. A person should remain educable. The professional continues learning. The entrepreneur continues learning. The leader continues learning. The institution continues learning. One of the most dangerous sentences a successful person can say is: "There is nothing more anyone can teach me."

Education that builds nations should produce people capable of continuing to educate themselves. Curiosity may be one of the most important leadership skills.

The Missing Student Was Being Educated

I return once more to Duku. The lecturer could have shouted. The lecturer could have punished him. Instead, the situation itself carried the message. The class was waiting. His absence had consequences. He understood. He changed. There is something elegant about that form of education. The lesson entered through experience. Years later, he

carried it from Japan to Uganda. Then he told it to me. Then it entered this book. Now you are reading it.

Think about the journey of one educational moment. One classroom. One late student. One sentence. Years later, in another country, it becomes a conversation about leadership, institutions and nations. That is the extraordinary power of education. We never completely know where a lesson will travel.

What Should Education Produce?

Perhaps we can now answer the question with which we began. Education should produce knowledge. Absolutely. It should produce competence. It should produce scientists. Doctors. Developers. Engineers. Teachers. Entrepreneurs. Researchers. Artists. Accountants. Lawyers. Farmers capable of using better science. Citizens capable of understanding the world. But perhaps education should also produce people who understand: I belong to something larger than myself. My time matters. My work matters. Shared spaces matter. Truth matters. Other people matter.

The quality of what I contribute matters. If education can combine those things with intellectual excellence, then it does something far greater than prepare people for employment. It prepares people for society. And when millions of people enter society carrying those habits, education begins building nations.

A practical school experiment

Imagine a school that wants to improve care for shared books. Instead of beginning with a large character programme, it chooses one class and one month. The teacher and pupils agree how borrowing will work, allocate suitable duties and record common difficulties.

At the end of each week, they spend a few minutes reviewing the arrangement. Are books easier to find? Has anyone been excluded? Are duties shared fairly? Does a damaged book have a clear route for reporting and repair? The teacher also checks whether the work has become burdensome.

The school can then decide whether to adjust or extend the practice. It should not describe one successful month as proof of a transformation in every child's character. The evidence is narrower and still useful: a group has practised maintaining a shared resource and learned something about doing so.

That modest honesty makes the lesson stronger. Students see an institution evaluate its own work according to the standards it teaches.

Reflections for the Reader

How do my routines show learners that their presence matters?

Am I teaching those around me to carry responsibility, as well as to achieve results?

What do people learn from my example when something goes wrong?

Action Steps

Personal Practice: Ask yourself what your education has changed about your behaviour - not merely what it has added to your knowledge. Identify one character habit you still need to develop deliberately.

Leadership Practice: If you teach, supervise, parent or mentor others, choose one responsibility they can actually practice rather than merely hear about. Give responsibility with appropriate guidance, then allow the person to carry it.

Institutional Practice: Examine your school, university, company or organization and ask: What does this institution teach people through daily experience? Identify one contradiction between a value you publicly promote and a behaviour your system currently rewards or tolerates.

A Principle to Carry Forward

Education is incomplete when it teaches people what to know but never trains them how to live with others, carry responsibility and contribute to something larger than themselves.

Final Reflection

Great nations begin not with big speeches, but with small habits.

When schools teach knowledge and model character together, they become places where leaders are formed. The lesson lives in how we share a room, care for its resources, and help one another learn.

This is The Japanese Way.

Chapter 6

Ethical Business — Profits with Purpose

"The best businesses are not built with hype, but with honor."

— Najuna Saviour

A customer pays before the work is complete. For a moment, the transaction contains something that cannot be seen on the receipt: trust. The customer believes the business will deliver, communicate if circumstances change and handle the payment according to the agreement.

The business may be small. Its owner may be working from a single room, carrying several roles and managing an uncertain cash flow. None of that makes the trust less real. The payment may represent money the customer could not easily spare.

Ethical business begins by recognising the human weight of ordinary transactions. A quotation, a wage, a delivery date and a product description all shape another person's decisions. The question is how to build an enterprise that can honour those relationships while remaining commercially viable.

What the enterprise is for

Panasonic's published business philosophy offers a useful Japanese reference. It presents founder Konosuke Matsushita's view that an enterprise should contribute to society through useful products and services, and that the resources it uses carry social responsibility. The document also connects profit to the enterprise's contribution. These are the company's stated principles, not proof of perfect conduct or a guarantee that ethical firms always earn more. [7]

The question that follows is practical. What useful difference does this business make, and what must it earn to keep making that difference responsibly?

A business that continually loses the means to pay workers or maintain equipment cannot fulfil its promises indefinitely. Profit can fund continuity, training and improvement. It can reward the people who took a risk in building the enterprise. The issue is how that profit is earned and what costs have been left for others to bear.

An attractive margin may depend on unpaid overtime, misleading claims or suppliers who wait long after an agreed payment date. The accounts can look favourable while the operation consumes other people's trust.

Purpose should therefore influence the transaction itself. A charitable donation does not correct a product description that deceives customers. A motivational speech does not settle an overdue wage. The ordinary conduct of the business is where its values become testable.

The honesty of a quotation

Consider an illustrative software service offered to a small retailer. The developer quotes a low price to secure the work but does not explain that training, data transfer and ongoing support will cost extra. The customer assumes the quoted amount will produce a usable system. The developer assumes the additional work can be discussed later.

The conflict has begun before development starts. Both parties are planning around a different promise.

A responsible quotation describes the result, the main exclusions, what the customer must supply and how changes will be handled. It makes clear whether continuing costs exist. It avoids implying that a feature has been tested when it is still planned.

This clarity may make a price less immediately attractive, but it gives the customer a sound basis for deciding. It also protects the business from accepting work on terms it cannot sustain.

The same principle applies outside technology. A repairer should explain whether the estimate includes parts. A training provider should state what the fee covers. A supplier should distinguish stock in hand from an item that must be ordered.

Ethical selling allows the customer to understand the purchase well enough to refuse it. A decision obtained through confusion is a weak foundation for a lasting relationship.

The customer after the sale

Businesses often devote more attention to winning a customer than to helping one whose purchase has failed. The sales number is celebrated, while the unresolved complaint is treated as an interruption.

A better view follows the whole relationship. Can the customer reach somebody? Does that person understand the issue? Is there a clear route to repair, replacement or another fair remedy? Does the business explain what it can and cannot do?

Imagine a household appliance that fails soon after purchase. The customer does not need to know the internal boundaries between sales, service and the supplier before receiving help. Someone should take responsibility for coordinating the response, even if several parties must act.

The business should keep enough records to avoid asking the customer to repeat the same account indefinitely. It should make a promise about the next update and keep it. If the matter remains unresolved, that should be visible to someone who can make a decision.

Complaints also contain information about the product. Several similar reports may indicate a problem that deserves investigation before further sales. A business that closes each complaint separately can miss the pattern connecting them.

Service after failure is part of quality. It reveals whether the customer remains a person after becoming revenue.

Fairness toward employees

The people delivering a company's promise need clear terms, suitable tools and respectful treatment. A business cannot credibly promise dependable service while organising work through constant uncertainty for its staff.

This includes ordinary management decisions. Are responsibilities understandable? Are schedules communicated with reasonable notice? Can someone ask a question without ridicule? Is good work recognised fairly? Does the employee know how to raise a concern?

Panasonic's published discussion of people development emphasises recognising individual capabilities, giving employees opportunities to think and act, and developing people who can carry the organisation forward. Again, this is an articulated philosophy rather than an independent audit of practice. [8]

For a small enterprise, the application may be simple. Demonstrate a task properly. Explain why a check matters. Give a new employee a manageable responsibility and review it. Do not withhold all knowledge because trained staff might eventually leave.

A business that depends on keeping people unable to grow has a fragile relationship with its own future. Training may not guarantee retention, but refusing to train guarantees a limit on capability.

Fairness also means avoiding the assumption that loyalty requires unlimited availability. Staff have lives beyond work. A genuine emergency may require exceptional cooperation, but permanent emergency is a management problem that deserves attention.

Suppliers carry part of the business too

A business can appear reliable to customers while transferring uncertainty to suppliers. It orders urgently, changes requirements late and delays payment. The smaller supplier absorbs the resulting pressure because it fears losing future work.

The relationship is unequal, but responsibility remains. A buyer should communicate specifications clearly, authorise changes properly

and respect agreed payment arrangements. If a genuine difficulty arises, silence should not become the method of negotiation.

Long-term cooperation benefits from understanding the supplier's constraints. A lower price may be possible through a simpler specification or a more predictable order. Pressuring the supplier for an unexplained reduction can encourage hidden cuts in quality.

This does not mean accepting every supplier claim. Products still need checking, invoices need verification and performance needs review. Respect and scrutiny can coexist. The aim is a relationship where neither side depends on misleading the other.

The customer sees the final product, but the integrity of that product may depend on decisions made several relationships earlier.

Cash pressure is a test of judgment

An enterprise can face a difficult month even when its owner intends to act honestly. A customer pays late, a machine fails or an expected order disappears. Obligations remain.

The temptation is to solve the immediate problem by making a promise that shifts the difficulty forward. A deposit for a new project may be spent without ensuring the resources to complete that project. A delivery date may be accepted because the cash is needed, even though capacity is already full.

These decisions can turn a temporary shortage into a chain of broken commitments.

A responsible response begins with a clear picture of obligations and available resources. Which payments are due? Which work is already promised? What can be renegotiated honestly? What spending can wait? What new commitments would be misleading under present conditions?

This is not a substitute for professional financial advice when the situation requires it. It is a leadership principle: do not use another person's incomplete information as the hidden financing of your survival.

Sometimes an honest conversation will lose a sale. Sometimes it will preserve a relationship. The result is not guaranteed. Ethical business includes accepting that some opportunities cannot be taken on fair terms.

Conflicts of interest in ordinary decisions

Conflicts of interest do not arise only in large corporations. A manager selects a supplier owned by a relative. A committee member recommends a service from which they receive a benefit. An employee evaluates work done by a close friend.

The relationship does not automatically mean the supplier is unsuitable. The problem is that an interest may influence a decision that should serve the organisation or customer, and others may not know it exists.

Disclosure allows the decision to be handled fairly. The person can explain the connection and, where appropriate, step back from selection or approval. Comparable options can be examined. The reason for the decision can be recorded.

A small organisation may not need an elaborate policy for every possibility, but it does need a dependable habit of making relevant interests visible. Informality should not mean that the most connected person quietly benefits from every opportunity.

The test is whether the decision could be explained honestly to someone whose money or trust is involved.

Quality is an ethical matter

Poor quality creates costs beyond the maker's premises. The customer spends time seeking a repair. Another worker repeats the task. Materials are wasted. In some industries, people may face serious harm.

This is why quality cannot be treated only as a branding choice. The business has made a claim about what its product or service will do. Its

checking process should be appropriate to that claim and to the consequences of failure.

The Daihatsu case discussed in Chapter 2 is a reminder that a respected name does not remove this duty. Reputation should invite continued care, not justify less scrutiny. The practical question for any enterprise is where its own confidence is being asked to substitute for evidence.

For a small service business, useful evidence might include a completed check, a customer sign-off or a test of the result under actual conditions. For higher-risk products, much more may be required. The standard must fit the work.

Excellence is also honest about limitations. A modest product that performs its stated function reliably can be more ethical than a sophisticated one sold through claims its maker has not substantiated.

Purpose without performance theatre

Businesses increasingly describe their social purpose. Such statements can help clarify decisions, but they can also become another form of advertising.

A useful purpose should answer difficult questions. If the company says it values learning, does the budget allow training? If it says access matters, who is excluded by the way the service is designed? If it says community matters, what happens when a commercial decision imposes an avoidable burden on neighbours?

The evidence need not be dramatic. A clear returns process, reliable wages and honest product information may do more for everyday trust than a highly visible ceremony.

Claims about impact should be proportionate too. Serving ten customers does not establish transformation across a community. A training session does not prove lasting changes in employment. A business can describe what it did, what it observed and what it does not yet know.

The discipline of modest claims is especially important for enterprises that rely on a mission to attract support. Good intentions should make the account more careful, because people are being asked to trust both a service and a larger promise.

Building an enterprise that can continue

A founder's personal integrity matters, but it cannot remain the only safeguard. Customers should not receive fair treatment only when the founder is present. Staff should not need personal access to the owner to resolve every ordinary issue.

The business needs records and methods that carry its standards. Who can authorise a remedy? Where are customer commitments recorded? How are payments checked? What happens when a key person is absent?

These arrangements should grow with the enterprise. A simple business may begin with a short set of documented practices. As responsibilities become more complex, the need for independent checking increases.

Continuity also requires passing on knowledge. A successor should understand why a standard exists, not merely where the document is stored. The founder's role gradually includes making good conduct possible without constant personal intervention.

That is a meaningful form of legacy: an organisation whose users can still depend on it when its original builder is elsewhere.

Reflections for the Reader

What values drive my business or work?

Am I creating systems people can rely on—or shortcuts I hope no one notices?

If my company disappeared today, would the community feel the loss?

Action Steps

Trace one customer relationship from the first advertisement to support after delivery. Compare what is implied at each stage with what the business can actually provide. Correct one ambiguity that could cause a reasonable customer to misunderstand.

Then examine one internal relationship. Ask an employee or supplier which recurring uncertainty makes cooperation difficult. Choose a change within your authority and explain when it will take effect.

For reflection: What would my customer decide differently if they knew what I know? Which cost of my business is someone else carrying without clear agreement? Does our purpose influence difficult decisions? Can a staff member uphold our standard without needing exceptional personal courage?

Profits with purpose require a business to keep earning the trust on which it operates. Innovation adds a further challenge: the promise may be new, and its consequences may not yet be fully understood.

Final Reflection

Not every company will go global. But every business can choose to go deeper—in service, sincerity, and responsibility.

Let the customer find honesty in your promise, the employee find dignity in your workplace, and the next generation find something worth continuing.

This is The Japanese Way.

Chapter 7

Innovation with Integrity

"How you build matters as much as how fast you build."

— Najuna Saviour

A demonstration succeeds. The application opens, the machine runs, the presentation ends to applause. The creator has shown that something is possible.

The user's test begins later. The connection weakens. A record is entered incorrectly. A payment does not appear. The person who gave the demonstration is unavailable. Now the invention must function inside ordinary life, where conditions are less controlled and people have other concerns.

Innovation with integrity follows the product into that life. It asks who depends on it, what happens when it fails and who remains responsible after launch.

The principles explored in the earlier chapters help organise these questions. Discipline supports careful preparation. Responsibility gives failures an owner. Punctuality makes service commitments usable. Continuous improvement creates a way to learn after real people begin using the result.

Start with the problem people experience

An idea often begins in the creator's imagination. That is useful, but it is not enough evidence that the imagined problem is the one users need solved.

Consider an illustrative entrepreneur who wants to create a booking application for a local service. The first plan includes accounts, profiles and automated reminders. Conversations with customers

reveal that their main difficulty is more basic: they do not know whether the service is available or what documents to bring.

A simpler information page and a dependable confirmation process might address the immediate need better than a large application. The larger idea may still have value, but its priorities have changed.

Observe the whole task the person is trying to complete. How do they begin? What do they already use? Where do they hesitate? What do they do when the normal route fails? Ask about a recent real experience rather than only whether they like a proposed feature.

People may politely approve an idea they would never use. Watching a task and discussing actual decisions can reveal constraints that enthusiasm leaves hidden.

The purpose of this inquiry is not to ask users to design the entire solution. It is to ensure the creator is solving a problem that exists outside the presentation.

The promise should fit the first version

An early product can have a narrow purpose. That can be an advantage if the purpose is clear and the core function is dependable.

Suppose a service helps customers request appointments but does not yet connect to the organisation's full schedule. It should not tell users that a request is a confirmed booking. A clear message can explain that confirmation will follow and indicate when to expect it.

The distinction may seem small to a developer. For the person paying for transport, it can determine whether a journey is wasted.

Responsible innovation describes the current capability accurately. A planned feature belongs in a development discussion, not in a customer promise presented as already fulfilled. A test result should say what was tested and under which conditions. An impressive demonstration should not be treated as proof of reliable operation at every scale.

This discipline protects the team too. When claims outrun the product, staff spend their time managing disappointment instead of learning from use.

An honest first version creates room to improve without asking users to discover hidden limitations through avoidable loss.

Design for the conditions of use

A solution that assumes a new phone, a stable connection and fluent reading may exclude people who need the service. A process that depends on one specialist may fail when that person leaves. A machine that requires unavailable parts may spend more time awaiting repair than doing useful work.

These are design questions. They should be considered before the appearance of the product is treated as complete.

For a digital service, this may mean testing on modest devices and under slower connections. It may mean using clear language, making errors understandable and ensuring essential actions can be completed without unnecessary steps. For a physical product, it may mean examining maintenance, spare parts and the skills needed for repair.

The appropriate decisions depend on the users. A specialist laboratory and a rural cooperative will have different requirements. Respecting local conditions is not lowering ambition. It is defining what successful performance actually requires.

The creator should also ask who has been absent from testing. People with disabilities, limited literacy or less confidence using technology may reveal problems that a team of experienced users never encounters.

Inclusion becomes practical when it changes a design decision.

Know what failure would mean

Not every defect has the same consequences. A misplaced heading and a duplicated payment deserve different levels of concern. A

responsible team identifies the failures that could cause serious harm and gives them appropriate attention.

Before a trial, ask what the user may lose: money, access, information, time, safety or the ability to make a fair decision. Identify which outcomes can be reversed and which cannot easily be repaired. Decide what must be checked before the product reaches people and what monitoring will be needed afterward.

An educational prototype used with a small group may allow rapid revision. A service making consequential decisions about people requires a more demanding process, suitable expertise and a route for those affected to seek correction. Calling something innovative does not reduce its responsibilities.

The point is proportion. Excessive procedure can prevent useful experimentation, while inadequate checking can transfer the cost of experimentation to people who never agreed to bear it.

A thoughtful trial limits exposure, explains its status and gives participants a clear way to report problems. Learning should not depend on concealing uncertainty from the people providing the experience.

Plan the day something stops working

A product is incomplete if nobody knows what to do when its main function fails. The response should be considered while there is still time to think calmly.

Who receives the report? How is the issue distinguished from an ordinary question? Who can pause the affected function? How will users learn what is happening? What records are needed to investigate without collecting unnecessary information?

Consider an illustrative ticketing service that cannot display tickets during an outage. A prepared operator might have an authorised alternative verification process, a clear customer message and a person coordinating recovery. An unprepared operator may ask each customer to solve the problem separately.

The backup arrangement must itself be usable. A document describing a procedure nobody has practised may provide reassurance without capability. A small exercise can reveal missing access, unclear decisions or an outdated contact.

After an incident, the review should examine both the original fault and the response. Did users receive accurate information? Did staff know what they could decide? Did the recovery create new errors? Reliability includes the ability to recover with honesty and care.

Information entrusted by the user

Digital products often ask for personal information because collecting it is technically easy. The more important question is whether the information is necessary for the service and whether the organisation can protect and manage it responsibly.

As a design principle, ask for the minimum information needed for a clear purpose. Explain that purpose in language users can understand. Limit access to people who need it and consider how long the information should remain available. Specific legal obligations vary and need to be checked for the service and jurisdiction concerned.

The ethical issue exists even before a legal dispute. A person may provide a telephone number to receive a service update without expecting unrelated promotional messages. A student may share information for an application without expecting it to appear in a public demonstration.

Trust depends on the relationship between the reason information was given and the way it is used. A long policy cannot compensate for a design that deliberately encourages misunderstanding.

The leader should be able to explain each significant collection decision without relying on “we might need it someday.”

Human judgment remains a responsibility

Automation can make a service faster, but speed does not answer the question of whether a decision is right. An incorrect record can be

processed very efficiently. A rule can be applied consistently while being unsuitable for a particular case.

Where an automated system affects an important opportunity or service, people need a meaningful route to question the result. Someone must have the authority and competence to investigate. A human who merely repeats the system's output does not provide effective review.

The organisation should also understand the limits of what it has built or purchased. If a tool generates a plausible answer, that answer should not be presented as verified simply because it is fluent. If a model performs well in one test setting, the team should not assume identical performance for every group and circumstance.

These are general leadership principles rather than instructions for one particular technology. The same concern arises whenever a process hides the reasoning behind a consequential decision.

Innovation with integrity makes responsibility visible even when the mechanism is complex.

Maintenance belongs in the original ambition

Launch receives attention because it is easy to photograph and announce. Maintenance is less visible. Yet it determines whether the promise remains available six months later.

An organisation should know who will update information, replace worn parts, handle support and pay continuing costs. A service that depends on a volunteer's permanent availability should be described honestly. A donor-funded installation needs a plan for the period after the initial grant.

This is a particularly important question when introducing technology into institutions with limited resources. The purchase price may represent only part of the burden. Training, connectivity, replacement, support and staff time can determine whether the tool remains useful.

The same reasoning applies to a book's digital learning platform or a community information service. Publishing content is one task; keeping it accurate, accessible and supported is another. An innovation should not leave the receiving institution with obligations it did not understand.

A smaller system that can be maintained may deliver more lasting value than a larger one that depends on resources no one has committed.

Adaptation is part of invention

Learning from a Japanese method does not require reproducing its visible form. A manufacturing practice may depend on supplier arrangements, skills or infrastructure that differ from those in another setting. Copying the outward procedure without those conditions can produce frustration.

The useful sequence is to identify the problem the method addresses, understand how it addresses it, and examine what conditions make it work. Then design an application that fits the local task and test the result.

For example, a small service team may learn from the idea of making problems visible without installing a factory-style display. A shared record of blocked work may serve the purpose. A craft workshop may learn from consistent quality checks while retaining techniques developed through local experience.

The adaptation should be judged by its results and effects, not by its resemblance to a photograph from abroad. People closest to the work should help shape it.

This is where innovation and cultural confidence meet. A community can respect an idea enough to examine it and respect itself enough to change the implementation.

Growth can change the ethical problem

A process that works for twenty users may fail for two thousand. A founder can personally resolve each complaint at first, but that is not a complete service model for growth. A manual check may be manageable at a small scale and become rushed as demand increases.

Before expanding, ask which part of quality currently depends on personal attention that cannot grow at the same rate. Identify the tasks that require clearer delegation, better records or additional capacity.

Growth also changes who is affected. Early users may understand the experimental nature of a product. Later customers may assume established reliability. Marketing should reflect the service's actual maturity.

Scaling a flaw can create harm faster than scaling a benefit creates value. The leadership decision is therefore not merely whether more people want the product. It is whether the organisation can serve them responsibly.

Sometimes the right next step is a better support process rather than a larger campaign.

Reflections for the Reader

Am I chasing innovation for impact—or for applause?

How would my product, service, or system look if I built it with discipline and dignity?

What would happen if every great idea also had to be a good idea?

Action Steps

Choose a product, service or institutional reform you are developing. Write one sentence describing the user's problem and one sentence describing the promise you can currently keep. Check whether your public language goes beyond that promise.

Then imagine a difficult ordinary day: a connection fails, a key person is absent or a user makes an understandable mistake. Walk through what happens next. Identify one gap in recovery or communication and close it before expanding the service.

Reflect on these questions: Who has not been included in testing? Which ongoing cost is absent from the plan? Can a user question an important decision? What would make us pause growth? Do we have evidence of usefulness beyond our own excitement?

Responsible innovation makes new capability dependable enough to enter everyday life. The next chapter considers how that work can contribute to African institutions without reducing a diverse continent to a single story.

Final Reflection

The future doesn't just belong to the fast—it belongs to those who can move forward without losing their foundation.

Build with the person who will use your work in mind. Let each improvement make their experience more dependable, and let your claims remain as honest as your ambition is bold.

This is The Japanese Way.

Part III

The Global Leader's Call

Chapter 8

Africa Rising

"We can become globally principled and locally rooted."

— Najuna Saviour

The phrase "Africa rising" can express confidence, but it can also become a substitute for examining what is actually changing. A new building, an investment announcement or a successful entrepreneur may be significant. None, on its own, tells us whether an ordinary person can obtain a service reliably or whether an institution will work next year.

I am interested in that ordinary experience. Can a student obtain an accurate record without repeated visits? Can a small supplier expect a clear decision? Does equipment receive maintenance before it becomes unusable? Can a person raise a concern without needing a powerful connection?

These questions are deliberately modest in scale. They help bring a large ambition within reach of observation. National transformation involves major policy and investment choices, but people encounter its progress through specific institutions and services.

The task is to connect hope with the capacity to keep a promise.

A continent is not a single case study

African countries have different histories, institutions, economic conditions and political choices. Communities within one country differ too. A practice that suits a large urban university may be unsuitable for a small rural school. A manufacturer's problem is not automatically a trader's problem.

This should make the conversation more precise, not less ambitious. Instead of asking why Africa is or is not disciplined, ask what prevents a particular organisation from delivering reliably. Instead of celebrating a general cultural trait, examine a practice that people can describe and test.

Broad judgments can obscure existing competence. An institution with serious constraints may contain employees whose work is careful and inventive. A country facing public difficulties may also contain businesses and community groups with much to teach. The point of reform is not to declare everyone deficient before improvement can begin.

Likewise, pride should not make failures impossible to discuss. We can acknowledge a working practice and still ask whether it is fair, sustainable or capable of serving more people. Confidence is strong enough to examine evidence.

The institutional middle

Development conversations often move between the individual and the nation. A young person is told to work harder; a government is told to transform the economy. Between those scales lies a large part of ordinary life: the school, enterprise, professional association, local office, cooperative and community organisation.

These institutions translate resources and rules into experience. Their procedures determine whether knowledge is used, whether a problem is noticed and whether work continues after a person leaves.

Consider an illustrative university department where student requests depend on one administrator's memory. The administrator may be dedicated, but absence creates uncertainty. A shared request record, clear requirements and a simple handover can make the service less dependent on a single person.

This is institutional improvement at a scale people can influence. It does not solve every funding or policy problem. It does make a particular responsibility more reliable.

The middle matters because it is where personal effort can become a repeatable arrangement. Without that step, improvement may vanish whenever the person who introduced it moves on.

An existing channel for learning

The Africa Kaizen Initiative provides a documented example of cooperation around improvement. JICA describes it as a ten-year initiative agreed with the African Union development agency in April 2017, intended to spread kaizen through centres of excellence while respecting country ownership. Its stated approach includes business capability and access to finance alongside quality and productivity. These are programme aims, not proof of uniform results across participating countries. [9]

The significance for this book is that learning has an institutional route. An idea does not have to travel only through a motivational speech or a visiting expert. It can be taught, adapted, reviewed and shared through organisations with continuing responsibilities.

My interpretation is that local capability should be a central measure of such cooperation. After the workshop ends, can people identify a problem, organise a trial and judge the result? Can they teach the method to a colleague? Can the institution continue without waiting for the external partner to return?

These questions help distinguish temporary activity from growing competence. A certificate may recognise attendance. A functioning improvement process demonstrates something else.

A hospital example from Tanzania

Japan's 2011 ODA White Paper describes the introduction of 5S and kaizen at Mbeya Referral Hospital in Tanzania. It reports leadership involvement, a quality improvement team and ward-level teams, as well as initial resistance from some staff who saw the work as merely cleaning. The account describes improvements in organisation and stock management. It also traces learning through experience in Sri

Lanka, showing that the exchange involved more than a direct Japan-to-Africa transfer. [10]

This is a historical programme account, not a current assessment of the hospital or a controlled evaluation of clinical outcomes. It should be read within those limits.

The leadership question it raises is why a useful practice can meet resistance. A task may be introduced without explaining its purpose. Staff may fear that extra duties will be added without support. Professionals may see an activity as unrelated to the work for which they trained.

These concerns deserve attention. A leader should show how a proposed change addresses an actual problem and invite staff to identify where the design is weak. People are more likely to understand a method when they can see how it affects the work they care about.

The wider lesson is also about humility in learning. Knowledge can move through several countries, acquiring experience along the way. A partner need not be the original inventor to make a valuable contribution.

Local products and local judgment

Another historical example appears in the same 2011 White Paper: One Village One Product activity in Kenya. The account describes support for products using local resources and residents' creativity, with an emphasis on developing the people who could sustain the work. It gives examples of groups exploring products and markets rather than receiving a single externally prescribed product to make. [11]

This is a description of a development approach and selected examples at that time. It does not establish the present performance of every project associated with the name.

The principle worth considering is ownership of the economic decision. A community needs to understand the customer, the cost of

production and the work required to maintain quality. External encouragement can help, but it cannot replace that knowledge.

Imagine a group producing a locally distinctive item. An attractive sample is only the beginning. The group must learn whether buyers value it, whether materials are dependable, whether the price covers the work, and whether repeat orders can be fulfilled consistently.

Here, craft and management meet. Local identity can distinguish the product, while dependable delivery allows the customer to trust it. Learning from another country need not erase what makes the product local. It may help the maker carry that value more reliably into a market.

What the examples do and do not establish

The Egyptian educational cooperation in Chapter 5, the hospital account from Tanzania and the enterprise approaches discussed here show that cross-cultural learning already takes practical forms. They do not prove that one method can transform a continent, or that partnership automatically produces durable results.

Programme descriptions are often written by organisations involved in the work. They can provide valuable detail about intentions and activities. They should be read alongside independent evaluations, local accounts and evidence of what continues over time when those are available.

A reader can apply the same discipline to any success story. What changed? For whom? Over what period? Compared with what? Which difficulties remain? Who is describing the result, and what might they be unable to see?

These questions do not make hope smaller. They make it more useful. A clearly understood success can be adapted with greater confidence than an inspiring story stripped of its conditions.

Begin with a problem people recognise

Suppose a professional association wants to improve its service to members. It could announce a broad transformation programme, but a more practical starting point may be a recurring complaint: members cannot tell whether renewal payments have been received.

The association can trace the process from payment to confirmation. Perhaps records are split between two people, messages arrive through different channels and no one owns the final response. A revised method might establish one intake route, a daily check and a clear confirmation message.

The trial should include people who use the service, including those less comfortable with the chosen channel. It should examine whether the change reduces uncertainty and whether the staff can maintain it. If it works, the association can document the method and address another problem.

This hypothetical example is intentionally ordinary. Institutional credibility often grows through ordinary services that become less troublesome. People do not need to understand the language of reform to notice that an answer arrives when promised.

Resources still matter

A book about habits must not become an excuse for withholding resources. A school needs teachers and materials. A hospital needs qualified staff, equipment and supplies. A business needs access to customers and workable finance. Better organisation can help resources go further, but it cannot replace every missing resource.

An improvement effort should distinguish between what can be changed locally and what requires a larger decision. If a process has unnecessary steps, the institution may be able to remove them. If demand substantially exceeds capacity, the need for capacity should be documented and escalated.

Both responsibilities can be carried at once. A leader can improve how existing equipment is maintained while seeking replacement of unsafe

equipment. An office can clarify its procedures while making an evidence-based case for more staff.

The false choice between personal responsibility and structural reform serves neither. Careful local work can reveal structural needs more convincingly. Structural investment can make local good practice sustainable.

Avoid the imported programme that nobody owns

A familiar risk in reform is that the visible activity belongs to an outside partner while the continuing work belongs to people who were barely consulted. Training occurs, a launch is held and materials are distributed. Later, the method is rarely used.

Before beginning, the receiving institution should understand the problem being addressed, the responsibilities it is accepting and the resources required. Staff should be able to question the proposed method. Leaders should know who will maintain it and how results will be reviewed.

Language matters too. A method explained only through unfamiliar terms may appear impressive while remaining difficult to use. Translate the purpose into the language of the actual task. People should understand what changes on Monday morning.

External support can bring expertise, resources and a useful challenge to established habits. Its value grows when local people can adapt the work rather than simply reproduce it. A successful partnership should leave the institution more capable of making its own next decision.

Public service as a dependable relationship

The principles in this book are relevant to public institutions, but application must respect the duties and constraints of each service. A public office cannot simply choose only the easiest customers or the most profitable cases.

Reliability therefore includes fairness of access. Requirements should be understandable. Decisions should have a traceable basis. People

should know how to question an error. A service should not depend on a personal favour when it is meant to be generally available.

An illustrative local office might begin by publishing a clear document checklist, identifying official charges and recording the date each request is received. These steps will not resolve every deeper problem. They can make some parts of the service easier to understand and scrutinise.

The leadership test is whether the arrangement works for a person without influence. A system that becomes efficient only when an important visitor arrives is demonstrating selective attention, not dependable public service.

The contribution of professional communities

Professional associations, business networks and universities can help good practice travel between institutions. They can host practical reviews of what members tried, including what did not work. They can share methods that others can adapt and create opportunities for less experienced people to learn.

The discussion should go beyond success presentations. A useful session might examine how a team reduced missing records, how a school improved a handover or why a customer-support change failed. Participants should be able to ask about effort, cost and maintenance.

This type of exchange gives ordinary competence public value. It makes room for people whose work is useful but not highly visible. It also helps prevent every organisation from solving the same basic problem alone.

The group should avoid becoming a place where members endorse one another without scrutiny. Shared standards need the ability to discuss failures fairly. Respectful professional challenge is part of the service such a community can provide.

Passing learning between generations

Young people often hear that they are the future. They also need opportunities to carry a real responsibility now, with support appropriate to the task. A title without authority teaches little; a difficult assignment without guidance can become exploitation.

An institution can give an emerging leader a defined project, explain its constraints, provide access to an experienced mentor and review the result honestly. The mentor should ask for reasoning, not only obedience. The younger person should be allowed to improve a method rather than merely preserve it.

Older experience and younger questions can be useful to each other. A longstanding employee knows why a previous attempt failed. A new colleague may notice that circumstances have changed. Together they can distinguish a necessary safeguard from an old habit that no longer serves its purpose.

This is a practical form of renewal. It keeps memory without making the past the only source of permission.

A local standard with international meaning

A well-kept promise is intelligible across borders. A clear record, a fair correction and a product that works can earn trust without abandoning local language or identity.

The ambition is not that every African organisation should look Japanese. It is that useful principles should become locally understood practices. Once people adapt a method, test it and maintain it, they have knowledge of their own to contribute.

Learning can then travel outward again. An institution working under one set of constraints may develop a simpler or more inclusive approach that helps others. That possibility should be part of the relationship from the beginning.

I want the confidence of this book to rest there: in the capacity to learn, build and contribute. Admiration of another society is only a

starting point. The work becomes ours when we make a standard real in the place for which we are responsible.

Reflections for the Reader

Which principle in this book speaks most directly to the needs of my community?

How can I lead differently without waiting for perfect conditions?

What value will I model even when the surrounding culture does not reward it?

Action Steps

Choose one institution you can influence and one recurring service problem its users recognise. Describe the current experience, identify who should participate in designing a change, and agree on a limited trial. Record what the trial can demonstrate and what it cannot.

Before borrowing a method, ask what conditions made it useful elsewhere. Identify which conditions exist locally, which can be created and which require a different design. Invite the people who will carry the method to revise it.

Reflect on these questions: Am I describing my own setting precisely or relying on a general story about Africa? What existing competence have I overlooked? Which resource need must be escalated? What knowledge could our experience contribute to somebody elsewhere?

Institutional progress becomes durable when people can inherit it and improve it. The final chapter turns to the leaders who will carry that responsibility.

Final Reflection

Africa's future will not be written only in conference halls or policy documents.

It will be shaped in the daily lives of people who show up, own their mistakes, build with excellence, protect trust, and refuse to compromise on integrity.

These values may be lessons we admire in Japan. But once practiced faithfully here, they become ours too.

This is The Japanese Way—and a challenge to every nation willing to learn.

Chapter 9

A New Generation of Ethical Global Leaders

"This is not a leadership style. It is a leadership standard."

— Najuna Saviour

The reader who finishes a leadership book still has to enter an ordinary day. Messages will arrive. Someone will make an unreasonable request. A task will be less clear than expected. A person with influence may want an exception. The principles that seemed straightforward on the page will encounter competing demands.

That is where leadership becomes a practice. The question is how to make a sound decision when no chapter contains the exact situation in front of you.

The answer cannot be a promise of moral perfection. It can be a dependable way of paying attention: to the facts, to the people affected, to the duties of the role and to the consequences of the available choices.

Begin with the responsibility already present

Leadership is often imagined as something that begins after appointment. Yet many of its duties appear before a title does. A person coordinates a group assignment, organises an event, maintains a shared record or helps a team complete a difficult task.

These responsibilities are small enough to dismiss and real enough to matter. They provide opportunities to learn how decisions affect others, how to ask for help and how to account for a result.

The point is not to pretend every act makes someone a chief executive. Different roles require different expertise and authority. The point is

that dependable conduct can begin within the responsibility a person already has.

Ask who relies on your work now. What uncertainty could you reduce for them? What promise needs attention? What decision have you postponed because it is uncomfortable? The next step may be less impressive than the leadership role you imagine, but it is available.

The values that become difficult

Most people can agree that honesty, fairness and responsibility are desirable. The challenge comes when values pull in different directions.

A leader wants to support a colleague but must address poor work that burdens the team. A business wants to keep its prices accessible but must cover the cost of dependable service. A school wants to apply rules consistently while responding to a student's unusual circumstances.

These tensions require judgment rather than a slogan. Begin by identifying the decision accurately. What is being requested? Who is affected? Which facts are established and which are assumptions? What responsibilities cannot reasonably be transferred to somebody else?

Then examine the options, including the option you would prefer not to consider. What harm might each create? Can it be reduced? Is the decision reversible? Who should be consulted before acting? Is there a relevant professional standard or duty that requires specialist advice?

Finally, give reasons that the affected people can understand, subject to legitimate confidentiality. A reasoned decision may still disappoint someone, but it is different from an unexplained exercise of power.

Loyalty and the courage to disagree

People sometimes treat disagreement as evidence that a person is not committed to the group. Yet a colleague who points out a serious flaw

may be protecting the group's purpose more faithfully than one who remains agreeable.

A leader should distinguish the manner of disagreement from its substance. A concern expressed awkwardly may still be correct. A polished presentation may still be misleading. The task is to examine the claim.

Those raising concerns also carry responsibilities. Be specific where possible. Separate what you observed from what you infer. Use appropriate routes and avoid spreading an allegation as established fact. Seek a response that addresses the problem rather than merely humiliating a person.

Where ordinary routes are unsafe or compromised, the situation may require independent advice or another legitimate reporting channel. A book cannot determine the right response to every serious conflict. It can insist that loyalty should not require hiding harm.

The healthiest team is not the one in which nobody objects. It is the one in which an objection can become useful information without destroying the person who raised it.

Power should make a person more accountable

As authority grows, a leader may receive less correction. People hesitate. They simplify difficult news. Access becomes controlled. The leader's intentions may be sincere while their picture of the organisation becomes increasingly incomplete.

Countering this requires deliberate arrangements. Hear from people outside the immediate circle. Examine complaints without treating all of them as attacks. Ask which decisions are difficult to question. Ensure that important checks do not depend entirely on the goodwill of the person being checked.

A leader should also be interested in ordinary experience when no visit has been announced. A service prepared for inspection may reveal its capacity to perform under attention, but not its usual conduct.

Authority creates the ability to set conditions. It therefore creates responsibility for the conditions in which others act. If staff cannot report bad news safely, the leader should not be surprised when the reports remain reassuring until a crisis occurs.

The more power a person holds, the less adequate personal confidence becomes as a substitute for scrutiny.

Make room for different forms of contribution

The image of a leader is often narrow: confident, quick to speak and comfortable in public. These abilities can be useful. They are not the only abilities an institution needs.

A careful listener may notice a concern others miss. A patient organiser may make the work possible. A technically skilled colleague may prevent an error without ever speaking from a platform. A person who asks for time to think may offer the clearest judgment later.

An ethical leader should create ways for these contributions to be heard. Circulate material before a meeting. Allow written input. Ask a question without immediately rewarding the fastest answer. Recognise work that supports others rather than only work that attracts attention.

This also protects the organisation from confusing style with competence. Confidence can make a claim persuasive before it is tested. Quietness can make valuable knowledge easy to overlook.

A new generation of leadership should widen the opportunity to contribute while maintaining clear standards for the work itself.

The private habits behind public conduct

A person's public decisions are supported by less visible habits: reading carefully, checking an assumption, preparing for a conversation and making time to review an error. These activities give judgment a foundation.

Reflection need not be elaborate. At the end of a week, a leader might review one decision that worked and one that did not. What information was available? What was overlooked? Did a personal preference influence the outcome? What should be handled differently next time?

The review should not become an exercise in permanent self-accusation. Its purpose is to learn. A person who treats every imperfection as proof of unworthiness may avoid looking closely at mistakes. A more useful stance accepts both responsibility and the possibility of growth.

For readers whose faith informs their lives, prayer and reflection may support this practice. For others, a quiet review or a conversation with a trusted colleague may serve. The practical test remains the conduct that follows.

Conviction becomes useful to others when it shapes a decision they can experience.

Relationships that can challenge you

A leader needs people who are not required to agree. A mentor, peer or trusted adviser can help examine a decision before it hardens into certainty.

Choose such relationships for honesty and judgment, not merely status. Explain the real question, including the facts that weaken your preferred option. Ask what you may be overlooking. If every consultation is arranged to confirm a decision already made, the process adds little.

The relationship should respect confidentiality and appropriate boundaries. A colleague is not responsible for carrying every difficulty in your life. Professional expertise is needed for some matters. The value of a thinking partner lies partly in recognising those limits.

Be willing to provide the same service to others. Listen carefully, ask specific questions and avoid offering certainty beyond what you

know. Mutual learning is one of the most practical forms of leadership development.

It is also a reminder that the person holding a title remains a learner.

Develop people who can continue without you

An institution that collapses when its leader leaves has not converted enough personal capability into shared capability. The leader may have worked hard and achieved much, but continuity remains vulnerable.

Succession begins before retirement or departure. It includes giving people meaningful responsibilities, explaining the reasons behind decisions and making essential knowledge accessible. It includes allowing someone else to become competent enough to disagree.

The founder who must remain the best-informed person in every conversation may unintentionally prevent the organisation from growing beyond them. Training others requires tolerating a period in which work is slower and questions are frequent. That investment can later make the institution more dependable.

A handover should contain more than passwords or files. It should explain current obligations, unresolved issues, important relationships and the reasons behind significant choices. The successor should know what remains uncertain, not inherit a polished fiction in which every difficulty has been resolved.

Continuity is an ethical duty because other people's lives do not pause when leadership changes.

Standards that survive a difficult month

Values are easiest to announce when resources are adequate and results are favourable. A difficult month reveals which standards have practical support.

If revenue falls, will the business describe its position honestly? If criticism becomes public, will the institution preserve the evidence? If a deadline becomes impossible, will the team communicate or conceal

the gap? If a respected person breaks a rule, will the response remain fair?

Preparation helps. Agree beforehand how problems will be escalated, which decisions require independent review and what communication is expected. A procedure cannot remove every moral difficulty, but it can make the responsible action easier to identify under pressure.

The same principle applies personally. Decide which commitments need protection and which activities can be reduced during a demanding period. A workable minimum can preserve continuity without pretending that every week has the same capacity.

Resilience is partly the ability to adjust honestly while keeping the purpose intact.

A commitment that can be observed

A leadership statement is useful when it names conduct. “I will lead with integrity” expresses an aspiration. “I will distinguish confirmed facts from assumptions when presenting a decision” gives the aspiration a test.

Choose a small number of commitments connected to your role. A manager might promise to give clear feedback and communicate changes promptly. A student leader might promise to keep accurate records and explain the use of shared funds. An entrepreneur might promise to describe the product’s limits before accepting payment.

Then consider what support the commitment needs. Does the record exist? Is time available for review? Is there someone who can point out a failure? A value without an arrangement may remain dependent on memory and mood.

Invite feedback from the people affected. They may see a gap between intention and experience. Listen for the specific issue instead of defending the whole of your character.

The aim is not to produce an impressive declaration. It is to make one part of your leadership easier to trust.

Returning to the classroom

I began with a friend arriving late to a lecture. I have been careful to keep that story within what it is: a personal recollection that opened a larger inquiry.

Its power for me lies in a simple recognition. Duku was part of a shared undertaking. His presence mattered, and so did the time of the people already in the room. He carried that understanding away and later shared it with me.

The book has followed that relationship into other places. A customer depends on a business. A pupil learns from the way a school is organised. A colleague relies on a clear handover. A community uses an institution long after the person who founded it has moved on.

None of these relationships is sustained by inspiration alone. They need preparation, truthful information, competent work and a way to respond when something goes wrong.

Japan has provided practices and examples worth examining. Africa has provided the place from which I ask how those lessons can become useful. The responsibility belongs to each reader wherever they live.

You do not need to imitate a country to take another person's time seriously. You do not need a large organisation to make a clear promise. You do not need a public platform to repair an error or teach someone how to carry a responsibility.

The next opportunity is likely to be ordinary. Someone will be waiting for your answer, your work or your decision. Begin there.

Reflections for the Reader

Which principle in this book has changed the way I see myself?

Where am I already leading—and what can I refine?

What would the world look like if I led with dignity, even in the small things?

Action Steps

Write a short leadership commitment using three observable actions connected to your present responsibilities. For each, identify the person who should experience the difference and the arrangement that will help you keep it.

Review the commitment after thirty days. Describe what changed, what did not and what you learned. Ask one affected person for a specific example of their experience. Revise the method where necessary without rewriting the record to look better.

Finally, choose one responsibility that depends too heavily on you. Teach another person how to carry an appropriate part of it. A useful final test of leadership is whether your example leaves someone else more capable.

Final Reflection

The Japanese Way is not a path reserved for a few.

It is a discipline, a direction, and a decision—available to anyone willing to choose character over comfort, purpose over popularity, and impact over ego.

Let the world say of you—not that you were perfect—but that you were principled, consistent, and trustworthy.

That is true leadership. That is your calling.

That is The Japanese Way.

Appendix

Putting the Principles to Work

The following tools are designed for individual readers, small teams, schools and enterprises. They are starting points for discussion and practice. They are not validated psychological assessments, institutional certifications or substitutes for specialist professional guidance.

Choose the tool that addresses a real difficulty. Completing every exercise is less useful than applying one carefully and following through.

A leadership self review

For each question, record a recent example, one limitation and a next action. Avoid assigning yourself a flattering score without evidence.

Discipline: Which important commitments did I complete as agreed? Which depended on a last-minute rescue? What arrangement would make the work more dependable?

Responsibility: When something went wrong, what did I acknowledge and repair? Did I give the affected person a useful update? What remains unresolved?

Punctuality: Where did I protect another person's time? Where did I create avoidable waiting? Did my original promise reflect the actual work?

Improvement: What change did I test? What evidence helped me judge it? Did I listen to the people who carried its effects?

Education: What responsibility have I helped someone learn? Did I give appropriate support? Can the person now do more without relying on me?

Enterprise: Where did my organisation's interests conflict with a customer's, employee's or supplier's interests? Was the decision transparent and fair?

Innovation: What limitation of our service have we explained honestly? What happens if it fails? Who can help a user correct an important error?

Institutional learning: What useful practice is documented? What still depends on one person's memory? Who could improve the practice next?

A thirty day practice plan

During the first week, observe one recurring problem. Speak with someone affected and record several actual instances. Define the problem narrowly enough that a change is possible within your authority.

During the second week, agree on one practical alteration. State the purpose, who will act and what improvement should look like. Identify one possible unintended consequence. Keep the trial small enough to stop or revise if necessary.

During the third week, use the revised method and collect proportionate evidence. Record exceptions rather than hiding them. Ask whether the people doing the work can maintain the arrangement.

During the fourth week, review the result. Decide whether to keep, adapt or stop the change. Document the reason. If the change is useful, teach it to another person and agree when it will be reviewed again.

Thirty days is a convenient trial period, not a scientific promise about habit formation. The appropriate period depends on how often the activity occurs and what evidence is needed.

A record for an important commitment

Write the agreed result in a sentence. Add the date or service window, the person responsible, the information needed from others and the way completion will be checked. Record any uncertainty that could affect the promise.

If circumstances change, update the affected person before the deadline where possible. Keep the original commitment visible alongside the revised one so that the record remains honest.

Example for discussion: A team promises a reviewed event programme by Thursday afternoon. The record identifies who checks names and times, when the organiser must supply missing information and who sends the final version. If a speaker has not confirmed, the programme should show that uncertainty rather than inventing confirmation.

A short review after a failure

Describe what was expected and what actually happened. Identify who was affected and what immediate repair is needed. Separate established facts from assumptions.

Trace the process, including instructions, resources, decisions and checks. Identify the individual responsibilities involved without using a convenient person as the whole explanation.

Agree on a correction, an owner and a date to check whether it worked. Where serious harm, misconduct or specialised issues are involved, use the appropriate formal process and expertise.

End with the communication still owed to the affected people. An internal meeting does not complete an external responsibility.

A discussion guide for reading groups

Meeting one can explore discipline and time. Ask participants to describe a commitment that affects another person. What makes it easy or difficult to keep? Agree on one practical experiment before the next meeting.

Meeting two can examine responsibility and improvement. Discuss what happened in the experiments, including failures. Use one example to distinguish an individual action from the process surrounding it.

Meeting three can address education and enterprise. What does your organisation teach through its everyday conduct? Where does a stated value conflict with an incentive or routine?

Meeting four can focus on innovation and adaptation. Choose a method borrowed from elsewhere. What problem was it designed to solve? What local conditions would require a different implementation?

Meeting five can examine continuity. What knowledge would disappear if one person left? Identify a useful handover or learning opportunity and agree who will carry it forward.

Participation should remain respectful. Do not require people to disclose private experiences or discuss identifiable colleagues without an appropriate purpose. A hypothetical scenario can support serious learning without exposing someone else's personal information.

A test for a story worth repeating

Before using an inspiring anecdote, identify its source. Is it a firsthand account, an institutional description, a news report or a story repeated without an identifiable origin?

Check the details that carry the lesson: who acted, what happened, when it occurred and why the action was taken. Distinguish sequence from cause. An event occurring near a graduation does not by itself establish that graduation caused a closure decision.

Ask whether the account has become more dramatic as it travelled. Have a station and an entire railway line become confused? Has an apology become a resignation? Has remembered speech become an exact quotation?

If the facts cannot support the claim, narrow the claim, identify the uncertainty or use another example. A principle worth teaching does not need an embellished history.

Research Notes and Sources

Source notes identify the material used for the factual examples. Notes support the specific factual accounts marked in the text. They do not imply endorsement of this book. Institutional sources describe their own policies or programmes; the book distinguishes those descriptions from independently established results. The book's illustrative scenarios and exercises are original applications, not reported case studies.

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Chapter Quotations

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About the Author

Najuna Saviour is a Ugandan author, entrepreneur and software developer. His interests include technology, education, enterprise and the everyday practices through which people build dependable institutions.

The Japanese Way grew from a conversation with his friend Duku Micheal about studying in Japan. It asks how people can learn across cultures and apply useful principles with judgment in their own communities.

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